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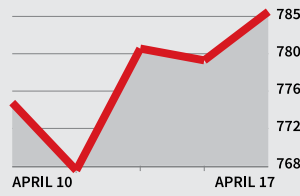
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	Week's close	Week's change
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P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.55	+0.24
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.92	+0.20
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151048.00	+1323
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	249940.00	+10006

LEGAL TANGLE.

Retrospective I-T Act amendment on the JAO's role *vis-à-vis* the FAO has triggered fresh litigation **p4**



ACT INTACT.

Government clarifies that there is no intention to modify the Delimitation Act **p5**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

LOGISTICS

Shipowners navigate Strait of Hormuz crisis



For over 40 days, staff handling the helpline at the UK-headquartered International Seafarers' Welfare and Assistance Network have been fielding anxious calls from marine crew members stranded in the Persian Gulf. A third of these calls pertain to difficulties faced by seafarers in returning home, while others are about employee rights. **p10**

BRANDLINE

How content creators are making curiosity 'cool'

Turn to Instagram and scroll through the inevitable food, beauty and entertainment reels, the cats and dogs content and, suddenly, the algorithm seems to be shifting. Popping up more and more frequently are fun quizzes and trivia tests by both global and Indian creators. **p8**

PIL alleges breach of trusteeship norms in Sir Ratan Tata Trust

RED FLAG. 'Provisions of Section 30A of Maharashtra Public Trusts Act, 1950, violated'

Raghuvir Srinivasan
Chennai

The battle over control of the Tata Trusts has acquired yet another dimension with a public interest litigation filed by a lawyer with the Charity Commissioner, Mumbai, on Saturday, drawing his attention to a violation in the matter of lifetime trustees on the board of Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT).

The petition, filed by lawyer Katyayani Agrawal of law firm SV & Co, sought "urgent intervention", alleging that SRTT, which has three lifetime trustees in a board of six members, violated the provisions of Section 30A of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act, 1950.

This section, introduced through an amendment in September 2025, says perpetual or lifetime trustees can make up only one-fourth of a public trust's board. The ratio is now half in SRTT.

Agrawal is understood to have filed the petition on behalf of her senior, Justice T Raja, who retired as acting Chief Justice of the Madras

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The current trustees in SRTT are Noel Tata (Chairman), Venu Srinivasan (Vice Chairman), Vijay Singh, Jimmy Tata, Darius Khambata and Jehangir HC Jehangir
- Noel Tata, Jimmy Tata and Jehangir HC Jehangir are lifetime trustees
- Unless the trust board size is doubled, two of the present lifetime trustees will lose their privilege

High Court in May 2023.

When *businessline* contacted Justice Raja, he initially said that any interested person could file a petition as SRTT is a public charitable trust. But he later confirmed that the petition was filed on behalf of a client whom he declined to identify. An e-mail sent to Tata Trusts' CEO Siddharth Sharma did not elicit a response until the time of going to the press.

'DEFEATS AMENDED SECTION'

The petition argued that the continuation of three perpetual trustees defeats the object of the amendment, which was to prevent entrenchment of a small group of lifetime trustees, ensure broader accountability and

protect the public charitable character of trusts.

"Such violation renders the current constitution of the Board of Trustees illegal and liable to be rectified forth with," the petition argues, calling for an immediate inquiry into the composition of the board and a direction to the Trust to comply with Section 30A by reducing the number of lifetime trustees.

SRTT, set up in 1919, and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust are the two main trusts that together control 50.54 per cent shareholding of Tata Sons Pvt Ltd. The current trustees in SRTT are Noel Tata (Chairman), Venu Srinivasan (Vice Chairman), Vijay Singh, Jimmy Tata, Darius Khambata and Je-

hangir HC Jehangir. Of these, Noel Tata, Jimmy Tata and Jehangir HC Jehangir are lifetime trustees. According to the current law, there can be only one lifetime trustee on the board of SRTT.

Unless the trust board size is doubled, two of the present lifetime trustees will lose their privilege. Significantly, Jimmy Tata, younger brother of the late Ratan Tata, was already a lifetime trustee on the board when Noel, their half brother, was inducted into the board in 2019. The PIL aims to take aim at Noel now.

The petition has sought immediate intervention. "Given the high public profile of the Trust and the fact that it controls significant public charitable funds, any delay in intervention will perpetuate an illegal state of affairs and erode public confidence in the regulatory framework. I, therefore, request that this matter be treated as extremely urgent and appropriate action be taken within the shortest possible time," it said.

Also read p2

Tata Trusts to alter restrictive clauses in Bai Hirabai Trust deed

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The trustees of Tata Trusts have decided to initiate proceedings before the appropriate authority to alter restrictive clauses governing the eligibility of trustees in the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution, a move aimed at aligning the trust deed with the group's long-standing inclusive ethos.

The decision was taken at a meeting of the Bai Hirabai Trust's board on April 17 under Noel Tata's chairmanship. The trustees said the move seeks to correct anomalies in the 1923 trust deed, which introduced restrictions, including barring non-Zoroastrians from trusteeship, that were not part of the original codicil to the will of Sir Ratan Tata.

On April 20, the trustees emphasised that the original 1916 codicil did not impose any restrictions. They noted that the Bai Hirabai Trust was intended to be administered by the trustees of Sir Ratan Tata Trust without any limitations.

See p2

CAFE III norms may jack up car prices by up to ₹1.25 lakh

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The automobile industry is aligning with the April draft of the CAFE III norms, which will usher in a stricter fuel-efficiency regime from April 2027.

The transition is expected to raise car prices by ₹20,000-₹1.25 lakh, while imposing a compliance burden of ₹61,500 crore-₹1.48 lakh crore on manufacturers.

A *businessline* analysis, based on inputs from Fore-See Advisors and Kotak Institutional Equities, shows that entry-level car prices could rise by ₹20,000-₹35,000 initially due to upgrades such as idle start-stop systems, tyre pressure monitoring systems, low rolling resistance tyres and engine optimisation.

As norms tighten, additions, such as six-speed transmissions, better aerodynamics and 48V mild-hybrid systems, could push costs up ₹85,000-₹1.25 lakh by FY32. While fuel savings of about ₹15,800 annually are expected, payback periods may range from 3-6 years as upfront costs approach ₹1 lakh.

For automakers, the shift presents financial and structural challenges, alongside

an accelerated move towards electrification.

OIL IMPORT BILL

"The more pressing issue is the affordability of small cars," said Harshwardhan Sharma, Head of Auto Retail Practice at Nomura. At the same time, improved efficiency could cut India's crude oil import bill by ₹60,000-₹90,000 crore annually by FY32.

CAFE III, or the Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency norms, introduce costs in phases — starting with basic efficiency technologies in 2027, followed by transmission and aerodynamic upgrades by FY30 — and culminating in hybridisation and deeper electrification by FY32. "This is no longer just a compliance exercise; it is a strategic decision regarding portfolio and capital allocation," said Hemal Thakkar of Crisil. The shift is expected to redraw competitive dynamics. Tata Motors, with an EV mix of 14-15 per cent, is seen as well-positioned.

Maruti Suzuki could benefit from its lightweight portfolio, while Mahindra & Mahindra has a viable transition path. Hyundai and ICE-heavy players such as Skoda, Volkswagen and Renault-Nissan face greater challenges.

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PM to inaugurate Ganga Expressway on April 29

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the much-awaited Ganga Expressway on April 29, which will connect western Uttar Pradesh with the eastern region, strengthening the State's economic and social framework and making travel faster, safer and more convenient. After receiving approval from the Union Cabinet in 2020, the Ganga Expressway project was taken up on priority and has been implemented in record time. OUR BUREAU

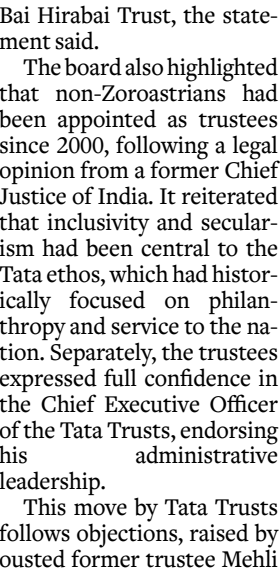
The decision was taken at a meeting of the Bai Hirabai Trust's board held on April 17 under the chairmanship of Noel Tata. The trustees said the move seeks to correct anomalies in the 1923 trust deed, which introduced restrictions, including barring non-Zoroastrians from trusteeship, that were not part of the original codicil to the will of Sir Ratan Tata.

In a statement issued on Sunday, Tata Trusts pointed out that the original 1916 codicil did not impose any restrictions based on ethnicity, race or religion. They noted that the Bai Hirabai Trust was intended to be admin-

MODEST ACTIVITIES
The trustees further clarified that the Bai Hirabai Trust is a non-shareholding entity with a limited asset base and relatively modest activities.

"In 2015, the objects of the Bai Hirabai Trust were enlarged to also cover the general public as beneficiaries of the activities of the Trust." They added, "There are no such restrictions as to qualifications for Trusteeship of SRTT nor of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) nor of any other Tata Trust."

Nonetheless, it is a fact that the trust deed made in 1923 by the then trustees contained restrictive clauses that, amongst other things, prohibited non-Zoroastrians from being trustees of the



Mistry, to the appointment of Vijay Singh and Venu Srinivasan to the board of Bai Hira Bai Trust, saying that they did not meet the eligibility condition of belonging to the Parsi-Zoroastrian faith. Srinivasan resigned from the Trust thereafter, while Singh continues to remain on the board. The admission by Tata Trusts that the eligibility criteria was restrictive is unlikely to lead to disqualification of earlier board appointees, said experts. "Because such appointments are generally assessed based on the governing rules in force at the time they were made," said Akshat Khetan.

When Srinivasan and Singh were appointed trustees for the first time and the change report was filed with the Office of the Charity Commissioner and it was accepted, "at that point of time the Charity Commissioner is presumed to have gone through the trust deed and all the conditions satisfied that they were rightfully eligible to be trustees," said a person with direct knowledge of the developments, adding that the regulator had approved it.

"The Trust has framed the issue as a historical inconsistency rather than an unlawful provision, and is seeking to correct it prospectively through legal processes. Unless a court or regulatory authority specifically finds that the restrictive clause was invalid under law or contrary to public policy from the outset, past appointments would typically remain valid, making this more a matter of future alignment than retrospective illegality," said Khetan.

services firms remain cautiously optimistic amid a volatile macro environment, with companies like Wipro and TCS highlighting steady tech spending and resilient client priorities despite geopolitical tensions and tariff-related disruptions weighing on visibility.

While some clients have adopted a wait-and-watch approach and budgets remain tight, investments in cloud, data and AI continue to hold firm.

During the company's Q4 earnings conference call, K. Krishnasnan, CEO and Managing Director, TCS, said that client demand in Q4 remained disciplined amid a challenging macro environment, shaped by geopolitical tensions, tariff-related uncertainty and stringent manufacturing and data-sovereignty requirements.

"Customers continued to prioritise cost rationalisation to fund a strategic pivot towards AI-led transformation, with spends focused on vendor consolidation, GCC expansion and structural efficiency and the resulting savings reinvested into scaling AI across core operations and product portfolios. Incremental investments were also directed towards digital sovereignty and supply-chain resilience," he observed.

CLIENT DEMAND

For TCS, in Q4, client demand across manufacturing remained cautious, shaped by macroeconomic uncertainty, tariff volatility and recalibration of EV demand. Despite continued restraint in capital expenditure across automotive, industrial and chemicals, customers prioritised near-term cost optimisation and operational resilience, with sustained focus

on AI-led productivity and cloud modernisation to streamline operations and improve reliability.

Similarly, client demand across BFSI remained technology-led through the quarter, shaped by heightened macro and geopolitical volatility. While uncertainty around interest rates, inflation and central bank actions influenced client sentiment, resulting in cautious investments, BFSI clients still prioritised core and legacy modernisation, data estate transformation and cloud migration. They scaled AI/GenAI deployments, productivity-led operating model transformation and vendor consolidation.

Echoing a similar tone, Srini Pallia, CEO and Managing Director, Wipro, addressed the conflict in West Asia during the company's Q4 earnings conference call. "There is no specific impact in terms of how we deliver to our clients, and it continues. Some of our clients are wondering whether to hold off on spending or reevaluate their projects. We continue to monitor the situation. While currently there is no significant impact, there are a few projects that clients want to slow down."

NEW NORMAL

Commenting on the energy, manufacturing and resources segment, he said he does not see the conflict having an impact at this moment. He added that geopolitical tensions have become a new normal for clients.

The systematic investment plan (SIP) stoppage ratio last month crossed 100 per cent for the first time in the last 11 months, as volatile markets made investors jittery, with one- and two-year SIP returns turning negative in the last few months.

counts opened last month, according to data from the Association of Mutual Funds of India.

The SIP stoppage ratio stood at 76 per cent in February, with 49.7 lakh accounts stopped, while 65.72 lakh new accounts were opened.

Jeevan Kumar KC, Head-Investment Advisory Services, Geojit Financial Services, said markets over the last two months had dipped 16 per cent, leading to widespread SIP stoppages as in-

He added that investors should stay calm and aim to accumulate more units during bad times to reap the real benefit of compounding in inevitable bear markets.

The number of SIP accounts discontinued or matured increased to 53.38 lakh, against 52.82 lakh new accounts opened last month

had remained paused for three consecutive months. In FY25, the industry's stoppage ratio was 76 per cent, with 514.17 lakh accounts closed and 679.85 lakh accounts opened.

Despite the stoppage, SIP inflows increased 21 per cent last fiscal to ₹3.5 lakh crore, up from ₹2.89 lakh crore in FY25.

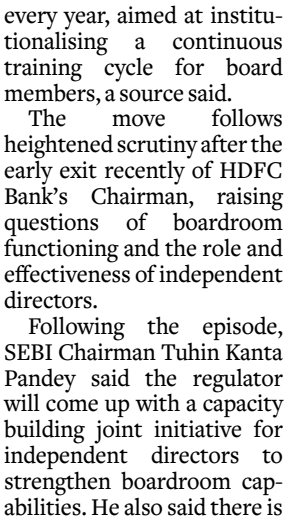
However, the markets have shown positive signs since the start of this month, with early signs of peace returning in West Asia.

Aditya Agrawal, Chief Investment Officer, Avisia Wealth Creators, said the rise in the SIP stoppage ratio reflected short-term volatility and some investors pausing contributions amid recent market corrections rather than a structural slowdown in systematic investing.

The recent market rebound may be followed by intermittent volatility, but India's structural growth story and earnings trajectory remain supportive.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has begun work on introducing mandatory, biannual workshops for independent directors, with attendance likely to be linked to their re-appointment after completing a five-year tenure, according to people familiar with the development.

The initiative is in collaboration with the National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM) and the Bombay Chartered Accountants Society (BCAS), which has already submitted a draft curriculum to the regulator. The proposal is currently undergoing review.



a need for a "continuous, structured and collaborative approach to learning" for board members as companies face increasingly complex regulatory and business environments.

Under the plan, independent directors will be required to undergo training at least once every five years, creating a system akin to continuing professional education norms applicable to other professions. The workshops will be conducted twice every year.

"Chartered accountants are required to complete continuing professional education hours every year, whereas independent directors currently do not have such a requirement. These workshops are expected to become an equivalent regulatory mandate," said a person aware of the discussions.

ducary responsibilities, risk governance and emerging areas such as technology and cyber risks, though final details are yet to be formalised.

It may also include case studies on governance failures and evolving expectations from audit committees and board-level oversight, another source said.

Once SEBI approves the curriculum, BCAS and NISM will work on it and conduct the workshops.

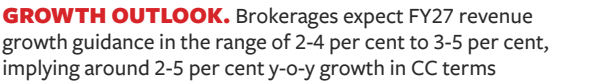
SEBI may mandate the same through a circular and in regulations.

At present, independent directors must meet eligibility criteria and register with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, but there is no mandatory requirement for ongoing training.

The proposed initiative is expected to address this gap by moving towards a system of continuous professional development and periodic upskilling.

Infosys is set to report its Q4FY26 results on April 23, with expectations of muted sequential performance, marginal margin improvement, and a cautious FY27 growth guidance of around 2-5 per cent in constant currency amid macro uncertainty.

Below are a few other key metrics to look out for:



ance with a marginal uptick of 0.3 percent to 2.8 percent, alongside a year-on-year increase of 8.2-9.4 percent.

According to Kotak Institutional Equities, the sequential revenue decline is largely driven by fewer billing days and seasonal weakness. It expects revenues from the sale of third-party items to remain stable, while a sharp decline in other income following the completion of the buyback could lead to moderate net profit

growth. Various brokerages expect FY27 revenue growth guidance in the range of 2-4 per cent to 3-5 per cent, implying around 2-5 per cent y-o-y growth in CC terms.

TWO FACTORS

Kotak Institutional Equities noted that two factors dominate this guidance outlook. First, elevated geopolitical risk from the Iran war adds uncertainty to global macro conditions and enterprise spending visibility. Second,

GenAI-driven productivity programmes are increasingly deflationary.

These factors are likely to cap headline growth guidance despite a reasonable deal pipeline. However, a prolonged or intensifying conflict would pose downside risks to both demand assumptions.

75 bps from the Versent acquisition is baked into the guidance, noting that the management expected the deal to close by the end of the fiscal year.

Alongside, an Equirius Securities report said EBIT margins are expected to improve marginally by about 8 bps q-o-q, supported by tailwinds from forex and cost/revenue efficiencies under Project Maximus, along with likely lower variable pay.

These gains are expected to be partly offset by headwinds from fewer billing days, the absence of certain one-time gains seen in Q3 and higher visa costs.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Sunday said it arrested a Deputy Director General at the Airworthiness Directorate of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), along with a representative of a private company, in a ₹2.5 lakh bribery case.

According to the agency, the case was registered on April 18 against the DGCA official and the private individual based in New Delhi.

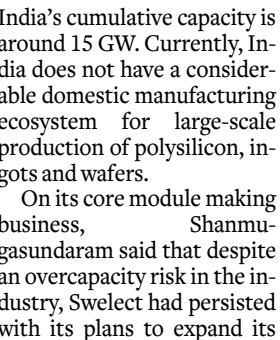
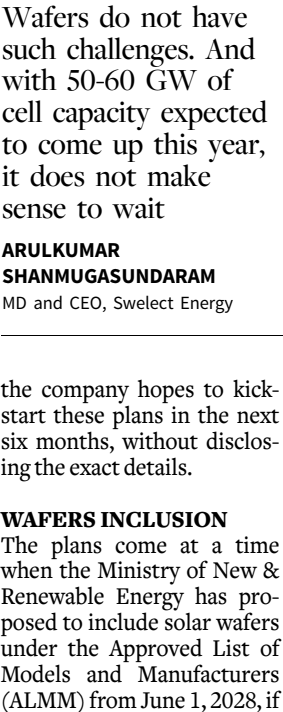
The allegations pertain to the public servant demanding undue advantage from private parties in lieu of granting approvals and permissions for applications pending with the regulator.

Chennai-based energy solutions company Swelect Energy Systems is actively evaluating its entry into the wafer manufacturing business.

In an interview, Arulkumar Shanmugasundaram, MD and CEO, Swelect Energy Systems, said that, compared to cell manufacturing, wafers are relatively easier with lower complexity and fewer regulatory hurdles.

“We missed out on the cell bus because of some regulatory challenges, especially Tamil Nadu’s ‘red category’ norms regarding pollution control. Wafers are much easier and do not have such challenges. And with 50-60 giga watt (GW) of cell capacity expected to come up this year, it does not make sense to wait,” he said.

Shanmugasundaram said



module manufacturing capacity to 2 GW. The demand, Shanmugasundaram believes, will be spurred by the company's deeper focus on rooftop solar, especially in the northern markets.

"We have a focus on the rooftop market and now we have got the empanelment and have established distribution networks in Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Rajasthan. The plan to grow in these markets," he said.

Shanmugasundaram said the company plans to launch other hybrid and BESS products in the next three months, while also expanding into the US market. Swelect is also on track to reach the 1 GW independent power producer target, where it builds solar power plants to generate and sell electricity.

Forex volatility, given the geopolitical tensions, has had a slight impact on the company's imports.

Blackstone-backed venture Hospitality Ltd (VHL) is tapping new markets in the Asia Pacific region to tide over the impact of the West Asia conflict on its international business.

The company owns 13 hotels in India and Maldives, with over 2,000 keys. In Maldives, it has three resorts under the Anantara, Conrad and Raaya by Atmosphere brands, and these contribute to around 40 per cent of its consolidated revenue. Overall tourist arrivals in Maldives have declined following the start of the war in February-end. VHL properties have been impacted, and the company is diversifying its customer base to keep occupancy intact. "We are targeting new source markets like Singapore, Japan, Korea, Australia and

New Zealand to mitigate the impact of cancellations in Maldives,” said Milind Wadekar, Executive Vice-President (Finance and Investor Relations). “There is minimal impact on our hotels in Pune (which have around 750 keys) which are supported by IT and other manufacturing industries,” he added. Other properties are

situated in Bengaluru, Goa and Mumbai. While the business environment is challenging now, Ventive is expected to report growth in the fourth quarter FY26 results.

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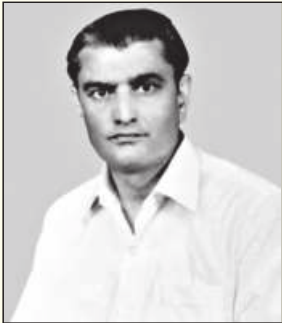
ALL INDIA BANK EMPLOYEES ASSOCIATION

OUR BELOVED UNION - A.I.B.E.A.

BY C.H. VENKATACHALAM, GENERAL SECRETARY



Comrade Prabhat Kar
The main architect of AIBEA
13th October, 1910 - 27th November, 1984



The ever inspiring
Comrade H L Parvana
3rd November, 1923 - 18th April, 1975

AIBEA, the household name amongst the bank employees of our country, was founded on 20th April 1946 when India was still under British rule. This sapling has today grown like a banyan tree, into a mighty and strong organisation, protecting and promoting the interest of the bank employees of our country. AIBEA has transformed the lives and living standards of the bank employees in the last eight decades.

From anarchy in service conditions, paltry wages and virtual slavery, today, bank employees have travelled a long distance and are enjoying better wages, enviable service conditions, job security, strong trade union rights, etc.. From a situation, where entering into the cabin of even the Branch Manager needed guts and courage, today the representatives of the employees have the right to become Workman and Officer Director in the Board rooms of the banks and are in a position to question the policies and functioning of the top management.

By their sheer unity, militancy, struggles and sacrifices, bank employees have advanced inch by inch and in the process built up a glorious trade union movement in the Banking Industry. When we meet on an occasion like this, it is our bounden duty to recall and recollect the past generation of leaders and bank employees, who had the courage, conviction and commitment as well as vision and farsightedness needed for forming a trade union for the employees in those days. Looking back, to organise the typically middle class minded employees in the Bank was not an easy task. The employees were virtually in the grip of fear of being sacked and victimized by the management for trade union activity. There was also no other organisation for such middle class salaried employees to look up to and follow on.

In this background, the pioneering role of taking the lead in organizing the employees in a service industry like bank was cast upon the AIBEA. Hence, the very formation of AIBEA shall remain important water shed in the history of middle class trade union movement of our country. When the bank employees were sinking under humiliation, degradation and deprivation, some conscious and courageous bank employees were looking to the surroundings, where the workers in factories and industrial establishments had organised themselves into trade unions and were able to achieve some improvements in their conditions through the path of agitation. This role led to a synthesis in the minds of those daring youngsters of that time, who started to feel the need that Bank employees also must form themselves into a trade union and fight for their upliftment. In the post Second World War situation, the prices went sky rocketing and everything went out of the reach of the salaried people. All these compulsions also contributed to the conviction that trade union must be formed for the bank employees.

Sporadically, here and there a few unions were formed in some Banks and in some States. These were sought to be crushed in the bud by the managements. Some of their demands were referred to Tribunals. But, there were no satisfactory solutions to the problems.

In this backdrop, on the 20th April 1946 in Calcutta, the banner of All India Bank Employees' Association was unfurled.

It is notable to remember that when this apex body was founded, there was no union in all the Banks in all the States throughout the country. Still, our founding fathers had the vision that the organisation should encompass the bank employees of the whole country. The birth of AIBEA gave the great fillip and momentum and number of unions were started in different Banks in many States. Further, formation of unions led to agitations and strikes in various banks, which of course ended in Tribunals and they achieved some relief. Bank managements were able to sense the growing militant movements of the bank employees and came to the conclusion that it would not be possible for the State Governments to fully control the situation. Consequently, Banking, which was hitherto a State subject, was made into a subject of the Central Government. This only added to the unity of the employees and their co-ordination on All India level as compared to the earlier period when the bank employees' movement was confined to the respective States. When banking became a Central subject under the Industrial Disputes Act, all the subsisting disputes in the Banking Industry were referred to a National Tribunal headed by Justice K.C. Sen. This was in June 1949. By August 1950, the Sen Tribunal gave its Award and employees could procure some benefits. But the Bankers went on appeal and in April 1951, the Sen Award was declared null and void on some technical grounds.

Hence, the disputes in the banking industry remained unresolved. This led to militant protests throughout the country and there was increasing unrest amongst the Bank employees.

At that stage, in January 1952, the Government appointed the Sasstry Tribunal. In March 1953, Sasstry Tribunal gave its Award, which resulted in wage cut.

Once again, powerful agitation was launched. The matter went to an Appellate Tribunal, which gave some remedy to the employees. But, the Central Government headed by Jawaharlal Nehru unilaterally modified the LAT's decision to the detriment of employees.

Against this, the 1st All India Bank Strike was observed on 23.9.1954. Then AIBEA also gave the call for indefinite strike from 10th December 1954. The then Labour Minister Shri V.V. Giri resigned from the Cabinet, protesting against the Government's decision. The struggle of the Bank employees thus created a crisis in the Government.

Consequently, the Banking Award Commission came and bank employees' stand was vindicated and the actions of the Government were pushed back.

After the expiry of this Award, once again the problems of the Bank employees were referred to K.T. Desai Tribunal in 1960.

In 1964, the AIBEA at its Trivandrum Conference decided "No more Tribunals, we must go for direct negotiations".

The struggles thereafter heralded the first ever industry level Bipartite Settlement in 1966. This was been one of the richest contributions of the AIBEA to the trade union movement in our country. Again, with the sad experience that the Banks were not playing the proper role in the national development, the AIBEA demanded that the Banks must be nationalised in the interest of the nation and its economy. The bitter struggle thereafter resulted in the historic political events in our country - Bank Nationalisation on 19th July 1969. This is also a commendable contribution of the AIBEA for national development. The developments thereafter, the successive industry level Bipartite Settlements in the Banking Industry as well as the unprecedented contributions of the nationalised banking system in the last more than five decades, need not be elaborated in details as all of us are well aware of the same. In the last 35 years, when in the name of economic reforms dictated by IMF and World Bank and pressurized by the developed capitalists and imperialistic countries, banking industry has been sought to be swallowed and privatised. It has been once again our beloved AIBEA, which has risen to the occasion and till today has succeeded in thwarting the evil designs of these machinations.

It is again our beloved AIBEA, which has transcended beyond its normal trade union responsibilities, which is today engaged in a crusade like mission in saving the bank employees, their jobs and job security and the trade unions in the Banks. Hence, the history of AIBEA is an inspiring saga of unity of the employees, united and militant struggles and a visionary approach to the problems of the employees and industry. It is this glorious movement that has been bequeathed to the present generation of the Bank employees, who are the direct beneficiaries of all the achievements of AIBEA all these years.

The future of the movement is cast on the shoulders of the present generation of bank employees and given the tradition to which all of us have been baptized into, we can say with pride and confidence that we shall continue the march ahead to a greater glory and overcome all the attacks and obstacles.

AIBEA – The Right Path of the Bank Employees:

Ever since its inception, AIBEA has been moving ahead with clarity, conviction and determination. Every step being taken by AIBEA, every struggle unleashed by AIBEA, every achievement of AIBEA signified the right path of AIBEA. Our continuous struggles have thwarted many efforts of the Government in their reforms agenda.

Our struggles have enabled the Banks to continue in Public Sector which in turn has ensured the safety of our banking sector against the global turbulence and financial crisis which many countries have witnessed and fallen a victim in the recent period. Our struggles have ensured the job security. The BP Settlements and particularly the pension option settlement are wonderful achievements in the present circumstances. Pension Option Settlement signed by all the unions is a vindication of AIBEA's right slogan and its achievement in 1993.

AIBEA has decided further struggles against the merger attacks and challenges. If AIBEA moves forward, all of us are safe. Hence it is the duty of every one of us – our units, our leaders, our members – to strengthen AIBEA which means strengthening ourselves.

After all AIBEA is our inspiration and motivation in all our activities.

AIBEA IN ITS 80TH ANNIVERSARY

The 81ST Founding Day of AIBEA is being celebrated on 20th April, 2026. AIBEA has completed 80 years today. 20th April - It is a red letter day in the annals of history of the bank employees movement. AIBEA completed 80 years of journey and entered its 81st year, assiduously following the path of unity and steadfastly marching along the path of struggles. This has enabled AIBEA to reach the towering height of reputation and standing amongst the comity of trade unions in our country. Now we are in the 80th year of AIBEA.

When we look back at the path traversed by AIBEA since 1946, we are proud of the glittering pages of history, and the militant path that we have travelled so far.

AIBEA – the pride: From a seed sown in 1946, AIBEA has grown into a mighty banyan tree today. We are the oldest and the largest trade union of bank employees in our country. By sheer dint of unity and constant and consistent struggles, AIBEA has achieved a lot for the bank employees. AIBEA has transformed the lives and living standards of the bank employees.

From Tribunals to Bipartism, from pitiable wages to better wages, from hire-and-fire to job security, from unilateralism of managements to negotiated service conditions, from anarchy and slavery to regulated service conditions, from ill-treatment to dignity and self-esteem, from middle-class vacillations to working class orientation, from denial of recognition to nomination of Workman Directors – these are some of the notable advancements during the last seven decades. Right from the beginning we have fought against every successive Government at the Centre when they confronted the bank employees. This is our glory; this is our strength; but then, this adds to our responsibilities.

Kidher dekho AIBEA: AIBEA not only represents bank employees in the nationalised public sector Banks but also has its members in the private sector Banks and foreign Banks, Co-operative Banks and the Regional Rural Banks. Even the Daily Deposit

Collectors, Contract-outsource employees, bank jewel appraisers and Bank Mitras/Business Correspondents-BC are part of our AIBEA. We have also our AIBEOA representing the officers. AIBEA has membership in all the States and in all the Banks. It will be astonishing to know that AIBEA members are spread-over in more than 1,00,000 bank branches all over the country, including in the most rural villages and hamlets. AIBEA has such a vast organisational network with its flag flying everywhere. In every Bank, in every State, in every Centre, AIBEA's red flag is flying high.

AIBEA – the harbinger of unity: AIBEA has been built up on the principles of unity of the bank employees and has mobilized the broadest possible unity under the banner of the trade union movement. AIBEA has been nurtured on the basic tenets of trade union democratic values. For us in AIBEA, unity is a fundamental principle and not a covert strategy. That is why AIBEA could hinder, thwart and overcome all the attempts of disruption from various quarters so far and continues to march on triumphantly.

AIBEA – the saga of militancy: Coupled with its unquenchable thirst for unity, AIBEA has also been committed to the path of militancy and struggles. Right from the inception, it is the path of militant struggles that has been the inherent and innate strength of our organisation. The long catalogue of our struggles from 1946 against all attacks, against the policies of the Governments, against bankers, etc. is a glorious saga and a highly inspiring part of our history and onward march.

AIBEA – synonym of sagacious leadership: No doubt AIBEA has been built up with the unity of bank employees, but the sagacious leadership, that AIBEA was fortunate to be endowed with since its inception, has steered our organisation in the right direction. The vision and conviction of our great leaders have taken our organisation in the right path. That is why even today, when we remember our great Leaders like Com. Prabhat Kar, Com. H L Parvana, Com. Tarakeswar Chakraborti, Com D P Chadha, Com N Sampath and all other outstanding and illustrious leaders of our movement, we feel instantly inspired. They suffered and sacrificed for the cause of our movement. We should ever remain indebted to them. When we recollect the past history of AIBEA, let us salute them and pledge to tread along the path shown by them and carry forward the organisation to newer heights and greater glory.

AIBEA – the patriot: AIBEA is well-known for its significant achievements in the sphere of improving the wages and service conditions of bank employees. We also believe that we have a broader role to play and a wider task to perform. Banks represent people's money and people's savings is the social capital. Banks have to augment, preserve and deploy this precious savings of the people and, to achieve this goal, the banking policies should have a social orientation. Banks should be in public sector. Banking industry should subserve the interest of the nation and its masses. It was for this patriotic cause, AIBEA fought and achieved nationalisation.

When in those days, many hundreds of private banks were collapsing and common people were losing their money kept in the Banks, it was AIBEA that fought against it inside and outside the Parliament. Because of this Banking Regulations Act was amended in 1960 and since then not a single banks has been closed down. This is another facet of our patriotic commitment. And now we are fighting against privatisation, dilution of social banking, looting in the name of bad loans and against dictated banking reforms. But for the struggle and resistance of bank employees, banking sector would have been privatised long back and met the same catastrophe and fate as was faced by the banks in USA and other countries. Thus, AIBEA fought with a patriotic commitment and saved the country from a serious banking crisis. That is why our AIBEA is iconic. Today when bad loans and NPAs are threatening to kill our Banks, it is again AIBEA which is spearheading the campaign and struggle against this serious lot of public money.

Tasks ahead – Get ready: When we are proud of our past, we must make the future glorious by our unity, by our activities and by our organisational endeavours. We have to fight against attacks on our jobs and job security, against outsourcing of permanent jobs, fight for more recruitments, fight against attacks on our right to collective bargaining, fight against attacks on our wages and service conditions, fight against attacks on bipartism, fight against the day-light corporate loot and fight for recovery of NPAs / bad loans.

We have to fight for a vibrant people-oriented banking sector keeping as our goal "People's money for people's welfare and not for private profiteering and loot".

Struggle for Nationalisation of Banks

Banks in 1947: AIBEA was founded on 20th April, 1946, a year prior to independence of our country. At the time of Independence in 1947, there were 648 Commercial Banks, comprising 97 Scheduled and 551 non-Scheduled Banks. The number of offices of the banks stood at 2987 with total deposits of Rs.1080 Crores and the advances at Rs.475 Crores.

The Indian Banking was entirely in the hands of the private sector. In addition to the Reserve Bank of India, there were five big banks, each holding public deposits aggregating Rs.100 Crores and more viz., Central Bank of India Ltd., Punjab National Bank Ltd., Bank of India Ltd., Bank of Baroda Ltd. and United Commercial Bank Ltd. All other scheduled commercial banks, which were also in the private sector, had regional character. Many of them held deposits of less than Rs.50 Crores. Even the Reserve Bank of India was not completely owned by the State until it was nationalized in terms of the Reserve Bank of India (transfer to Public Ownership) Act, 1948.

Post-independence: Independence brought many changes into the economic activity and the sphere of banking was not an exception to this. The deposits of the scheduled commercial banks constituted nearly 87% of the total deposits and the share of non-scheduled banks was a mere 6%. Despite its tiny share, the Scheduled Commercial Banks dominated the banking industry by capturing the lion's share of business. Many banks failed after independence due to partition of the country. The first and foremost task before the RBI was to build a sound banking base in order to achieve economic development. Prior to independence, the role of commercial banks in India was confined to providing vehicle for the community's savings and attending to the credit needs of only certain selected and limited segments of the economy. It was expected of the commercial banks soon after the independence to boost the economy by extending credit to the needy sector like agriculture, small and medium industries, artisans, self-employed etc. The issue of bank failure in some measure was addressed by the Banking Companies Act, 1949 (which was later renamed as Banking Regulation Act). But, it was only to a limited extent. The Act aimed at protecting the interests of the depositors and covered various aspects like organisation and management, audit and supervision of banking companies. This enactment giving powers to RBI did boost the confidence of the general public about their savings in commercial banks. The Banking Companies Act of 1949 conferred on the Reserve Bank extensive powers for banking supervision as the central banking authority of the country. But, since the bank failure continued even after independence, even though it was considerably reduced after the enactment of the Banking Companies Act, in order to protect public savings, the need was felt to amalgamate the insolvent banks with stronger banks.

Amendment to Banking Regulations Act: Accordingly, during 1950s, efforts were turned towards putting in place an enabling legislation for consolidation, compulsory amalgamation and liquidation of banks. It took more than a decade since 1950, to enact Banking Companies (Amendment) Act, 1961, to clarify, supplement the provisions of Sec. 45 of the Banking Companies Act, which related to compulsory reconstruction or amalgamation of banks. AIBEA played its due role in ensuring supplementary provisions to Sec. 45 of the Banking Companies Act was introduced due to effective debates in Parliament by the then General Secretary of AIBEA, Com. Prabhat Kar. The legislation enabled amalgamation of more than two banking companies by a single scheme. Between 1954 and 1968, several banks were amalgamated or otherwise ceased to function or their liabilities and assets transferred to other banks. The decade of 1960s also witnessed significant consolidation in the banking industry with 566 commercial banks consisting of 92 scheduled and 474 non-scheduled banks, functioning in the 1950s getting reduced to 89 by 1969, of which 73 were scheduled and the remaining 16 were non-scheduled.

Rural Credit Survey: The Reserve Bank of India, through the powers vested on it, announced in August, 1951, its decision to sponsor a country-wide Survey in order to obtain a factual basis for the formation of long-term policy in the sphere of rural credit. The Rural Credit Survey revealed that the role of Cooperatives in the Rural Credit was a mere 3.1%, with more than 70% of rural and agricultural credit concentrated on moneylenders and the rest from other sources such as traders and landlords. This was the most startling revelation.

SBI is born: Hence, the Government of India and the RBI surprised by these facts about lack of rural credit from cooperatives and formal sources like banks had enacted the State Bank of India Act, 1955, under which RBI took control of the Imperial Bank of India, which was renamed as State Bank of India (SBI). Later, in 1959, the State Bank of India (Subsidiary Banks) Act, was passed enabling SBI to takeover eight princely-State-associated banks as its subsidiary. The conversion of the Imperial Bank of India into State Bank of India and the constitution of the Associate Banks accelerated the pace of extending banking facilities all over the country. The object of formulation of the State Bank of India from 1st July, 1955, by acquiring the assets and liabilities of the then Imperial Bank of India, was to extend the banking facilities on a larger scale, particularly in the rural and semi-urban areas and also to shift its focus from 'credit worthiness' to 'purpose worthiness'. A new branch licensing policy was designed in 1962 to address the issue of expansion of banking facilities in unbanked areas by examining the data on population per bank office. Agriculture Refinance Corporation was set up in 1963 to refinance Central Land Mortgage Banks, State Cooperative Banks and Scheduled Commercial Banks. In 1964, ceiling on interest rates on both deposits and advances was imposed to avoid unhealthy competition in the sector. Credit Authorisation Scheme was introduced in 1965 to control credit flow to the big borrowers. Under this scheme, banks had to take prior permission of RBI to sanction any fresh working capital limits above the prescribed norms. The planned economy commenced in our country in 1950 and it was expected that the scheduled and non-scheduled commercial banks would lend to the needs of the common man, uplift their living conditions and being an agrarian economy, to extend more credit to agriculture. Even though the bank branches of commercial banks from 1952 to 1967 increased, the branch expansion in rural areas varied between 13.1% to 17.9%, 43.3% to 50% in semi-urban areas and 33.5% to 38.9% in urban areas.

The population per branch declined from 136000 in 1951 to 92000 in 1960 and further to 65000 in 1967. But, the pattern of branch expansion remained unchanged. Most glaring aspect was that the credit to agriculture increased by a mere 0.1% between 1951 and 1967 and in contrast to this, credit to certain industries increased from 34% in 1951 to 64.3% in 1967.

Mahalanobis Committee report: In February, 1964, Mahalanobis Committee report was published. This report was the first official disclosure of the existence of a high concentration of wealth and income in Indian Society. The report stated that, "The wealth of the largest 20 industrial houses and groups had grown enormously in the private corporate sector during the period from 1951-1958." The Mahalanobis report also brought out the major element

of control of the industrial houses over the top 14 privately owned scheduled banks and also the State Bank of India. It exposed the significant link in the form of directors in the scheduled commercial banks and the large-sized industrial undertakings. This was corroborated by the fact that the increase in credit to certain industries grew from 34% in 1951 to 64.3% in 1967, with agriculture being neglected as the credit to the farm sector increased by just 0.1% between 1951 and 1967.

AIBEA's crusade for nationalisation: AIBEA has been demanding for Nationalisation of the Banking Industry to help the country's economy since its formation. This assumed greater significance when in the 3rd Conference of AIBEA, held in 1950 at Jalandhar, Punjab, the following resolution was moved with greater emphasis on Nationalisation of Banks.

"This Conference of the All India Bank Employees' Association while fully supporting and insisting on the fulfillment of Nationalisation of all Basic and Key industries, utility services and big concerns vital to the life of the country emphasises the immediate necessity of Nationalisation of all the Banking Companies. It further demands that nationalization must be accompanied by effective workers' control on the Boards of the management. Legislation to this effect should be immediately introduced so that the stronghold of foreign and indigenous finance capital over the economy could be ended and the Banks after Nationalisation could play an effective part in the planned development of the country."

In 1956, when the insurance sector was nationalized following the failure of insurance companies, AIBEA commenced its struggles more vociferously. AIBEA stated that the nationalization of the key industries would improve the wealth of the nation to secure better living conditions of the common people. An unofficial bill for nationalisation of banks was moved, at the behest and struggles of AIBEA, in Parliament but the then Government did not care to accept the bill. Therefore, the stage was set for further struggles by AIBEA for nationalization of banks. AIBEA highlighted that the Government of India did not implement the recommendations of the Rural Credit Survey and that the stipulation that SBI would open 100 branches every year was also not fulfilled. AIBEA also brought to light that most of the bank branches are situated in cities and urban areas and the vital agricultural sector is suffering from lack of banking facilities. AIBEA also exposed that even though the amalgamation scheme of banks protects the interest of the depositors, the employees were rendered jobless. AIBEA had been consistently writing to RBI and the Government about the malpractices being committed by the industrialists in connivance with the top-level executives of the banks through their unholy nexus. AIBEA demanded that the only solution to check such anti-social activities was to nationalize the banking industry. AIBEA campaigned that the banking should play its proper role in the development of the country. Vigorous campaign was being launched by AIBEA and on 17th February, 1963, All India Day was observed for Nationalisation of the Banks. Since 1955, AIBEA had been seriously urging for the nationalization of the banking industry. Intense campaigns were launched, meetings and seminars were held. AIBEA and the bank-wise unions besides the State Federations gave memorandum to the MLAs, MPs, and political parties in support of this demand. AIBEA crusaded that for checking malpractices in foreign exchange, hoarding in godfarms, crushing concentration of wealth in the hands of a few, gearing up agriculture, removing disparity in income, checking rise in prices, the Banks should be Nationalised.

In this background, the Government of India, could not withstand the agitation of the bank employees under the banner of AIBEA on the one side while the economy was losing its grounds without proper concentration in key areas since the first Plan in 1950.

Call for struggle: AIBEA, from its Conference held in 1964 in Trivandrum demand immediate nationalisation banks and declared nationwide struggle. Bitter struggle ensued. The demand of AIBEA was echoed in Parliament. Communist Party of India played a leading role in the Parliament to highlight the demand of AIBEA.

Com. Prabhat Kar, the then General Secretary of AIBEA, who was also a Member of Lok Sabha at that time, spearheaded the debates inside the Parliament. However, dubiously, the then Deputy Prime Minister of the country and Finance Minister, Sri. Morarji Desai, brought Social Control Bill in December, 1967. Although the statement of objects and reasons contained a good deal of laudable objectives, the clauses incorporated in the bill, by no stretch of imagination, was to help in fulfilling the objectives for which the Bill was brought. The facade of Social Control Bill was to curb the trade union movement in banking sector instead of addressing the key issues of economy. AIBEA immediately took up the gauntlet and fought against the draconian provisions of Sec. 36 AD and Sec. 54 AA of the Banking Laws (Amendment) Bill, through strikes and struggles that sought to take away the right to strike and demonstrations. Petitions were submitted to MPs, MLAs, Corporation Councillors, Lawyers, Doctors, Scientists, Economists, Trade Unions and Political Parties. AIBEA also appeared before the Select Committee of the Parliament to which the Bill was referred.

At the instance of AIBEA, a deputation of Members of Parliament met the Prime Minister on 31.7.1968 and submitted a Memorandum to delete the provisions of Sec. 36 AD and Sec. 54 AA of the Bill. Several days strikes were observed by AIBEA. The comrades have plunged into action against these retrograde designs to curb the trade union activities. Under representations, agitations and pressure from AIBEA against the provisions of Sec. 36 AD of the Banking Companies (Regulations) Act, demanding its repeal, some Members of the Parliament moved amendments to the Banking Regulations Act to scrap this clause. AIBEA exposed the intentions of the then Deputy Prime Minister and Finance Minister, Sri. Morarji Desai, and demanded immediate Nationalisation of Banks. The Government was forced to take its decision about Nationalisation of Banks owing to the struggle of AIBEA vigorously since 1955 and the reports of the Rural Credit Survey, which was relevant even then and the revelation of nexus between the industrialists and the commercial banks in private sector of channelling the credit to a few industries with agriculture getting almost no improvement in loans since 1951, as clearly explained by the Mahalanobis Committee. The Government of India fully understood that the savings of the public were being channelized to boost the wealth of the industrialists and corporates and the Indian Banking industry instead of becoming an important tool to facilitate the development of Indian Economy was catering to the need of a handful of few. The then Prime Minister, Smt. Indira Gandhi, in this background both at the political and the economic fronts, expressed the intention of the Government of India in the annual conference of the All India Congress Committee meeting in a paper titled, "Strong thoughts on Bank Nationalisation". The paper was received with great enthusiasm.

Major Banks nationalised: The Government of India issued an ordinance and nationalized 14 largest commercial banks with effect from the midnight of 19th July, 1969. Within two weeks of the ordinance, the Parliament passed the Banking Companies (Acquisition and Transfer of Undertaking) Bill, and it received Presidential approval on 9th August, 1969.

The Banking Industry, as at 19th July, 1969:

	No. of employees	Total Deposits in Rs. Crores
State Bank of India	54935	1114
Subsidiary Banks	17602	326
14 Nationalised Banks	93000	3128
Banks under Public Sector	165537	4568
Foreign Banks	12000	487
Other Indian Banks	18000	100
Banks under private Sector	30000	636

Nationalisation challenged: On the enactment of the Bill, Supreme Court was moved challenging the Constitutional validity of the Act itself. After a marathon hearing of the petitions, the Supreme Court, on 10th February, 1970, struck down the Act as ultra vires of the Constitution on some technical points particularly relating to compensation. AIBEA called upon the Bank Employees for observing 2 - hours strike on 13th February, 1970, throughout the country demanding re-nationalisation of not only 14 banks but the entire Banking Industry. The strike was called at a very short notice but it was a tremendous success and the banking industry was paralysed.

Banks Re-Nationalised: On 14th February, 1970, the Government promulgated a new Ordinance re-nationalising 14 Banks. The second Ordinance became an Act after the Lok Sabha passed it on 24th March, 1970. Thus AIBEA undoubtedly deserved all praise and appreciation truly to its resolve to not only secure nationalization but also to defend it. AIBEA spared no efforts to scrap the obnoxious social control bill and also moved and crusaded for nationalisation of banks besides defending it till this date. The objective of the banks, for which they were nationalized, was to shed their urban bias, spread throughout the countryside with particular attention to backward areas and to diversify their credit in favour of sectors and categories of borrowers to whom facilities of institutional finance have so long been denied. Tremendous impetus was given to branch expansion. At the instance of the government, "Lead Bank Scheme" was launched, in terms of which, districts were assigned to various banks for undertaking quick survey and to open branches in areas in need of urgent banking facilities. The Nationalisation of the Banks was a great achievement on the part of AIBEA, because of the efforts undertaken since the Foundation Conference and thrust given since 1955 in every other way through demonstrations, rallies, seminars, meetings and representations to various political parties and trade unions. The Rural Credit Survey and the Mahalanobis Committee report besides the crisis in economic situation of the country and the political atmosphere of the country forced the then Government to Nationalise the Banks.

People should know that the same persons, who had challenged and supported the monopolies to file a petition in the Supreme Court of our country against nationalisation of banks, had tried to scuttle the process of Government ownership and tried to reduce the government equity to less than 33% during their regime in 1999. The ideologies and the route being taken by the present government are no different. The Honourable Minister for Finance has announced that apart from IDBI Bank, two more Public Sector Banks will be privatized. This is the grave danger. This is what has been fought against by AIBEA since last nearly 3 decades after the advent of new economic policies ushered in way back in 1991. Privatisation of Banks is a negative step in a developing economy like India. Indian Public Sector Banks represent the hard-earned savings of the people. Privatisation of banks would risk their savings as many private banks in the past have collapsed and people lost their savings. Private banks do not entertain loans to poor people and for the priority sectors. Their aim is only more and more profit. Service charges are more in private banks and common people will be affected. Rural branches may be closed in the name of non-viability. If Banks are privatised, employment opportunities will be reduced for the educated youth, and job will be on contract basis instead of permanent jobs. Job security will be affected. Reservation policy will not apply to private Banks and hence reserved category employees will be affected. Hence privatisation will only benefit the rich corporate houses who will buy these Banks. Already many corporate houses are defaulters of huge bank loans and there is a risk of such defaulters becoming owners of these Banks. Government says that some of the public sector banks were in losses and hence Government can no longer take care of them. The fact is that all public sector Banks are earning Operating Profits. Because of provision for bad loans some of the Banks were in net loss. So the priority is to take tough action on defaulters and recover the loans. But Government is encouraging more write offs and concession to Corporate defaulters.

Private Banks – history of mergers with Public Sector Banks			
S.No	Private Bank (Acquired / Merged Entity)	Merged with Govt. Bank	Year
1	Bank of Bihar	State Bank of India	1969
2	National Bank of Lahore	State Bank of India	1970
3	Krishnarao Baldeo Bank	State Bank of India	1974
4	Belgaum Bank	Union Bank of India	1976
5	Lakshmi Commercial Bank	Canara Bank	1985
6	Miraj State Bank	Union Bank of India	1986
7	Hindustan Commercial Bank	Punjab National Bank	1990
8	Traders Bank	Bank of Baroda	1990
9	Bank of Tamilnad	Indian Overseas Bank	1990
10	Bank of Thanjavur	Indian Bank	1990
11	Parur Central Bank	Bank of India	1991
12	Purbhachal Bank	Central Bank of India	1991
13	Bank of Karad Ltd.	Bank of India	1993
14	Kashinathi Sethi Bank	State Bank of India	1995
15	Punjab Co-operative Bank	Oriental Bank of Commerce*	1997
16	Bari Doab Bank Ltd.	Oriental Bank of Commerce*	1997
17	Bareilly Bank Ltd.	Bank of Baroda	1999
18	Sikkim Bank Limited	United Bank of India	1999
19	Benaras State Bank Ltd.	Bank of Baroda	2002
20	Nedungudi Bank Ltd.	Punjab National Bank	2003
21	South Gujarat Local Area Bank	Bank of Baroda	2004
22	Global Trust Bank Ltd.	Oriental Bank of Commerce*	2004
23	United Western Bank	IDBI Bank	2007
24	Bharat Overseas Bank	Indian Overseas Bank	2007
25	YES Bank – bailed out by	State Bank of India (lead investor)	2020

KICK OUT BAD LOANS BEFORE THEY KILL THE BANKS Non-Performing Assets	
31-3-2008	44,954 Crores
31-3-2009	59,927 Crores
31-3-2010	74,664 Crores
31-3-2011	1,170,000 Crores
31-3-2012	1,644,461 Crores
31-3-2013	2,167,739 Crores
31-3-2014	2,788,877 Crores
31-3-2015	5,39,956 Crores
31-3-2016	6,84,733 Crores
31-3-2017	8,95,600 Crores
31-3-2018	7,39,554 Crores
31-3-2019	6,78,318 Crores
31-3-2020	6,16,615 Crores
31-3-2021	5,42,173 Crores
31-3-2022	4,28,199 Crores
31-3-2023	3,48,457 Crores
31-3-2025	2,90,347 Crores

NPA – IBC HAIRCUT STORY (Rs. in Crores)

Borrower	Loan Amount	Settled and resolved for	Haircut for Banks in %	In Favour of
Essar	54000	42000	23	Arcelor Mittal
Bhushan Steels	57000	35000	38	Tatas
Jyothi Structures	8000	3600	55	Sharad Sanghi
DHFL	91000	19000	60	Piramal
Bhushan Power	48000	37000	60	JSW

QUICKLY.

AI to complete \$400 m retrofit programme by 2029

New Delhi: Tata Group-promoted Air India's \$400 million aircraft retrofit programme will be completed by 2029, a senior airline official said. Accordingly, the official was speaking at an event to showcase the airline's first retrofitted Boeing 787-8 (VT-ANT) which had undergone a comprehensive upgrade in the US. The aircraft is the first of 26 Boeing 787 planes undergoing a full cabin refresh programme. Besides, the official said that two retrofitted Boeing 787 aircraft set to rejoin the fleet in the coming months. The retrofit was carried out at Boeing's Modification Center in Victorville, California, followed by repainting at a Federal Aviation administration -certified facility in San Bernardino. OUR BUREAU

TVS Supply settles debt dispute with ZTE

New Delhi: TVS Supply Chain Solutions has settled its debt dispute with ZTE Telecom India and withdrawn its appeal in the NCLAT against an order that rejected insolvency proceedings against the telecom gear manufacturer. Earlier this week, the TVS Supply Chain counsel informed the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) about the settlement and requested withdrawal of the appeal. A two-member NCLAT bench, comprising Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan and Member (Technical) Barun Mitra, allowed the withdrawal for the plea. PTI

Retrospective jurisdiction fix triggers fresh tax disputes

LEGAL BATTLE. The latest round of litigation follows the Supreme Court's direction to petitioners to bring to the notice of their respective High Courts the legislative clarification with regard to disposed matters

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

A retrospective amendment to the Income-Tax Act, 1961, clarifying the role of the Jurisdictional Assessing Officer (JAO) *vis-à-vis* the Faceless Assessment Officer (FAO), has triggered fresh litigation across the country, with multiple High Courts set to hear petitions challenging the validity of the move.

Following directions from the Supreme Court, at least three such petitions have been filed this month in the Bombay, Karnataka and the Punjab & Haryana High Courts, challenging the retrospective changes made through the Finance Act.

The latest round of litigation follows the top court's direction to petitioners to bring to the notice of their respective High Courts the legislative clarification with regard to disposed matters.

The controversy surrounding the JAO and FAO centres around (a) who has the authority to issue income-tax reassessment notices, and (b) the legal validity of such notices issued under the post-2021 faceless regime.

While the Finance Act, 2021, introduced Section 151 A to mandate "faceless" assessments to increase transparency, many notices were still being issued by jur-

isdictional (physical) officers rather than the centralised faceless unit.

Taxpayers challenged these notices, arguing that assessments by a JAO lacked legal authority under the new regime. The High Courts have issued conflicting rulings on whether this is a "curable procedural lapse" or a "fundamental jurisdictional error" that renders the tax demand void, a tension that continues to trigger significant litigation across the country.

TO CLEAR THE AIR

Under the Finance Act, the Assessing Officer, for the purposes of Section 148 and Section 148A (of the Income Tax Act, 1961), "shall mean and shall always be deemed to have meant Assessing Officer other than the National Faceless Assessment Centre or any of its assessment units."

A corresponding amendment has also been made in the Income-Tax Act, 2025, so that the correct interpretation is taken, litigation is minimised and certainty is achieved. The clarification in the Income-Tax Act, 1961, has been made effective retrospectively from April 1, 2021, while the amendment in the Income-Tax Act, 2025, has come into effect from April 1, 2026.

This was done "to achieve certainty and clarity and



The controversy surrounding JAO and FAO centres around who has the authority to issue I-T reassessment notices, and the legal validity of notices issued under the post-2021 faceless regime

avoid litigation," the explanatory memorandum for the Finance Bill, 2026 said. The clarification to the 1961 Act and the amendment to the 2025 Act were necessitated after divergent views were expressed by various High Courts, some in favour of the revenue and others in favour of the assesseees.

The matter subsequently reached the Supreme Court, where the Tax Department filed special leave petitions against rulings of three High Courts — Punjab & Haryana, Bombay and Telangana.

This development is a legislative reset button designed to end the JAO-FAO controversy by siding entirely with the Tax Department's past actions.

By defining the Assessing Officer as someone "other than" the National Faceless Assessment Centre, the government is effectively legit-

imising the notices issued by local jurisdictional officers that were previously being struck down by the courts.

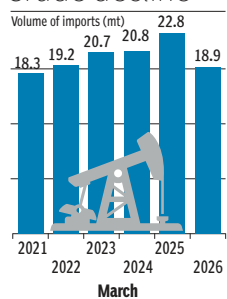
'ARBITRARY APPROACH' Experts have termed the retrospective move as 'arbitrary'. "This is a classic case of the Legislature trying to 'win' a pending legal battle by changing the rules mid-game. The retrospective amendment to Section 147A goes beyond mere clarification; it has, in fact, deepened the uncertainty around the JAO-FAO controversy at a time when the issue was nearing resolution before the Supreme Court, raising serious concerns of arbitrariness and legislative overreach," said Shaily Gupta, Partner at Khaitan & Co.

Ashish Agrawal, Partner at Dhruva Advisors, said the focus of the dispute had now clearly shifted.

War impact: Crude oil imports fall to 5-year low

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Crude decline



Source: Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell

Crude oil imports in March were the lowest for the month in the last five years as the West Asia conflict, which led to the continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz for more than 50 days and counting, impacted supplies from its largest suppliers in the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region.

According to the Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell, crude oil imports during March declined by 2.6 per cent m-o-m and 17 per cent y-o-y to 18.9 million tonnes (mt) provisionally. Imports in March fell for the third consecutive month. Besides, it is also the lowest monthly import in FY26. In fact, monthly imports in March are the lowest since September 2024.

Analysts attribute this to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, which has led to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz since February 28. Currently, around 30 per cent of India's imports that were to transit the Strait have been impacted.

KEY SUPPLIERS

Saudi Arabia, Iraq, the UAE and Oman are the key Indian suppliers, whose cargoes transit the world's most critical energy choke point.

As the conflict in West Asia intensified, India diversified its import basket reducing reliance on the Strait. In January and February, more than 50 per cent more than 50 per cent of India's exports transited the Strait.

To compensate for barrels

from the MEG region, India procured Russian crude oil at sea, which was aided by a 30-day sanctions waiver from the US. Indian refiners have bought a total of 60 million barrels of Russian crude oil since March 5. India purchased around 1.98 million barrels per day (mb/d) of Russian crude oil in March compared to a little over 1 mb/d during February, as per Kpler.

RUSSIAN OIL

The International Energy Agency (IEA), in its April oil market report, said importing countries received 4.4 mb/d of Russian crude oil in March, with India unloading 2 mb/d and China 1.8 mb/d.

Indian crude imports rose by 9,30,000 b/d month-on-month after the US waived restrictions on purchases for cargoes that were loaded before March 5. An estimated 22 million barrels of Russian oil came onshore in India in March, and 14 million barrels in China, wiping out the volumes at sea that had built up since October 2025.

In March, 12 Indian refineries processed Russian crude compared with seven in February, the IEA said.

ISMA seeks sops for flex-fuel vehicles in CAFE-3 norms as ethanol capacity outpaces E20 demand

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

With the draft Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE-3) norms under discussion, the Indian Sugar and Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) has urged the government to incorporate stronger incentives for flex-fuel vehicles (FFVs), arguing that the ethanol industry is facing a growing surplus capacity beyond projected E20 demand.

In a letter dated April 13 to Power Secretary Pankaj Agarwal, ISMA Director General Deepak Ballani said that provisions promoting flex-fuel vehicles and electrified flex-fuel vehicles should be explicitly included in the CAFE-3 framework.

EXCESS SUPPLY

The association flagged that unless vehicle technology adoption accelerates, the country risks significant excess ethanol supply in the coming years.

The intervention comes at a time when the government, in consultation with the



FISCAL SUPPORT. ISMA has called for fiscal support to improve market acceptance of flex-fuel vehicles

automobile industry on draft CAFE-3 norms, is considering the introduction of E25 fuel blends in the near future as part of a broader ethanol blending roadmap.

GST RATIONALISATION

Ballani also called for fiscal support to improve market acceptance of flex-fuel vehicles. Speaking to *businessline*, he said there should be rationalisation in Goods and Services Tax (GST) for such fuel and it must be brought to the level of electric vehicles at 5 per cent.

At present, GST on petrol and diesel vehicles not exceeding 4 m in length and with engines between 1200 cc and 1500 cc stands at 18

per cent, while larger luxury cars and SUVs attract GST of up to 40 per cent.

Emphasising the technological advantage of flex-fuel systems in the evolving fuel mix environment envisioned under CAFE-3, Ballani said, "The beauty of flex fuel is that it can take any blend — it can take E20 or E22 also, E50 or E100 or E85 also — so there should not be any binding to the customer. Tomorrow, if the customer wants to fill E20 or E22, the engine will take it. The flexibility should be given to the customer ... whatever is cheaper, the customer has the choice to fill that fuel."

He cautioned, however, that largescale transition to

flex-fuel vehicles will require time and sustained policy support. According to him, even though the policy direction is clear, fleet transformation cannot occur immediately. At the same time, he noted that widespread conversion of internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles to flex-fuel capability would place India in a strong global position in terms of energy flexibility.

Drawing parallels with global practice, Ballani pointed to Brazil's experience. He said that in Brazil, consumers choose fuels based on price, switching between blends such as E27 and E100 depending on affordability.

SUPPLY CAPACITY

On ethanol supply capacity, a central issue to the CAFE-3 debate, Ballani said India is already producing far more ethanol than required for current blending targets.

"Today, we have a capacity to produce 2,000 crore litres and 400 crore litre more capacity is coming up in this year itself. Then next year, we will have the capacity of producing 2,400 crore litres. For producing 20 per cent of ethanol blending, we only

need 1,100 crore litres. And, even if you do 22 per cent blending, it's only about 100 crore litres... So, we'll still have overcapacity."

Against this backdrop, the association urged the government to revisit provisions in the draft CAFE-3 norms that, in its view, may weaken incentives for flex-fuel adoption. In particular, ISMA expressed concern over the proposed reduction in the volume derogation factor for flex-fuel vehicles from 1.5 to 1.1.

Calling the move counter-productive, Ballani said, "This is an unexpected development, especially in the current context of energy crisis and ethanol surplus facing India, more so as there has been full convergence on this issue amongst stakeholders throughout. This is likely to discourage introduction of FFVs."

Industry stakeholders believe the final design of the CAFE-3 norms will play a decisive role in shaping India's vehicle technology mix, particularly as policymakers attempt to balance fuel efficiency targets, ethanol utilisation and long-term energy security.

Attack on Indian-flagged ships heightens uncertainty over Hormuz passage

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The attack on Indian-flagged ships in the Strait of Hormuz has brought renewed focus on the safe passage of Indian commercial vessels and the broader bilateral relationship between New Delhi and Tehran.

The Strait of Hormuz is critical for India's energy needs. Before the West Asia crisis, 2.5-2.7 million barrels per day (bpd) of crude oil from countries in the Arabian Peninsula used to pass through the Strait.

"It's back to square one with so much unpredictability on the passage of stranded ships in the Arabian Peninsula and being unable to pass through the Hormuz Strait," said an official of a large shipping line. "Every day, there is suspense in the region," he added.

'A SETBACK'

Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director and Global Head-Transport, Logistics and Mobility at Crisil Ltd, said that from a shipping trade perspective, the attack on Indian-flagged vessels represents a significant setback. "Private companies are



Ships and tankers in the Strait of Hormuz off the coast of Musandam, Oman REUTERS

inherently risk-averse when it comes to geopolitical exposure, and incidents like those in the Strait of Hormuz directly heighten concerns around cargo safety and crew security," he said.

Padmanabhan added that businesses would now prioritise minimising exposure to high-risk corridors, even at higher costs, seek stronger assurances from shippers, insurers and governments, and re-evaluate routing and sourcing strategies to avoid concentration risks.

Capt K Ramakrishnan, a Master Mariner, said that until now, the passage of Indian ships had largely been governed by government-to-government understandings. However, recent devel-

opments suggest that gunboat actions may not necessarily be coordinated with the Iranian government.

"The IRGC is possibly taking an independent decision," he said.

Michelle Wiese Bockmann, a maritime intelligence analyst based in the UK, said, "A very volatile and distressing situation west of Hormuz. Yesterday, when the Strait of Hormuz 'opened' and then shut so quickly, Windward detected at least 33 outbound ships reversing course mid-transit."

The events of the past 24 hours are a major setback for global trade. What nascent confidence there was among maritime stakeholders (shipowners, oil traders, war risk marine insurers, big container lines and oil cargo insurers, given so many laden VLCCs turned around) has evaporated. They won't be so quick to return next time till either Iran or the US declares the Strait open amid some tenuous ceasefire deal, she said in a social media post.

The Sanmar Group, whose ship reportedly came under fire, did not comment till the time of going to print.

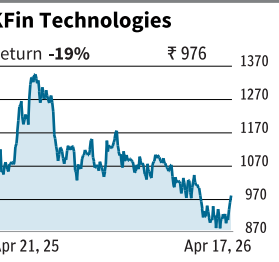
TODAY'S PICK.

KFin Technologies (₹976.05): **BUY**

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of KFin Technologies has been charting a sideways trend since the beginning of March. It has largely been oscillating between ₹870 and ₹950.

On Friday, the stock decisively broke out of the resistance at ₹950. Prior to consolidation, the trend was bearish. The way the scrip has been moving since the start of this year — a downtrend



followed by a sideways crawl and then a breakout — hints that the trend has turned bullish. We expect the stock to appreciate to ₹1,100 over the coming weeks. Traders can buy shares of KFin Technologies now at ₹976 and accumulate at ₹950. Place stop-loss at ₹900. When the price rises to ₹1,030, raise the stop-loss to ₹980. On a rally to ₹1,070, revise the stop-loss to ₹1,030. Book profits at ₹1,100.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Exchange drives up to half of jewellery sales

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Gold exchanges are no longer merely a distress-driven choice; they are fast becoming the default way Indians buy jewellery.

As prices remain elevated, customers are increasingly "rotating" their gold, using existing holdings as a form of currency to stay invested in the category.

The shift is now visible across large organised retailers, signalling a structural change in how gold consumption is financed.

At Titan's jewellery arm Tanishq, exchange-led purchases now account for more than half of total transactions, and the share continues to rise month-on-month.

CEO Arun Narayan said consumers are actively repurposing idle gold, a move that benefits both house-



PRECIOUS RESERVE. Indian households collectively hold over 25,000 tonnes of gold REUTERS

holds and the broader economy. "It is in the interest of consumers to reuse what is not being worn and in the interest of the country to reduce imports," he said, pointing out that Indian households collectively hold over 25,000 tonnes of gold, while annual imports stand at 750-800 tonnes.

MONETISATION

This behavioural shift is echoed across the industry. Joy Alukkas, Chairman and Managing Director of the

Joyalukkas Group, said the share of exchange-led transactions had been steadily climbing over the past few years.

"Rising gold prices have encouraged customers to monetise their existing holdings, which has supported continued buying even in a high-price environment," he said.

Exchange-led purchases, he added, were growing faster than overall sales as they offer a practical way to navigate high prices.

While the trend is particularly pronounced among middle-income consumers seeking affordability, it is increasingly visible among premium buyers as well, who are using it to upgrade their jewellery collections.

The acceleration is even sharper at Senco Gold & Diamonds. Managing Director and CEO Suvankar Sen said exchange now contributes about 45 per cent of overall sales, up from roughly 22 per cent two years ago.

"Customers are not stepping away from gold despite higher prices; they are simply becoming more efficient in how they buy," he said, adding that exchange-led transactions were outpacing overall sales growth.

Sen said the trend reflects a broader shift in consumer mindset. "Customers increasingly see their gold as an active asset rather than something idle," he said.

US team will head to Pakistan today for talks with Iran: Trump

Press Trust of India
Washington

President Donald Trump said US negotiators will head to Pakistan on Monday for another round of talks with Iran, raising hopes of extending a fragile ceasefire set to expire by Wednesday even as Washington and Tehran remain in a standoff over the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran did not immediately confirm the talks but its chief negotiator, Parliament Speaker Mohammed Bagher Qalibaf, said in an interview to state television that "there will be no retreat in the field of diplomacy," while acknowledging that a wide gap remained between the sides.

The White House said Vice-President JD Vance, who led the first round of talks last weekend, would lead the delegation to

Pakistan with envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.

Pakistani authorities began tightening security in Islamabad. A regional official involved in the efforts said the mediators were finalising preparations, and US advance security teams were already on the ground.

Ships remained unable to transit the critical waterway amid threats from Iran and a US blockade on ships heading to and from Iranian ports. Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil trade normally passes through the Strait, and the global energy crisis threatened to deepen as the war is now in its eighth week. Iranian officials earlier on Sunday held firm that ships wouldn't pass while the US blockade remained in effect. "It is impossible for others to pass through the Strait of Hormuz while we cannot," Qalibaf said.

QUICKLY.

At least 18 dead in cracker unit blast in Virudhunagar

Virudhunagar (Tamil Nadu): At least 18 people were charred to death and six others sustained grievous injuries following a massive explosion at a private firecracker manufacturing unit near here, police said on Sunday. The explosion occurred at the ‘Vanaja’ fireworks factory owned by one Muthumanickam, in Kattanarpatti near here. According to police and fire rescue officials, four of the six injured are in critical condition and are undergoing treatment at the Virudhunagar Government Medical College Hospital. The blast is believed to have originated in the front veranda area, where workers were allegedly handling raw materials. **PTI**

Chandrababu Naidu to campaign for NDA in TN

Hyderabad: Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu will tour Tamil Nadu for two days from Monday as part of the National Democratic Alliance’s (NDA) intensified outreach in the State. Naidu will begin his tour from Coimbatore. He will then travel to Hosur and proceed to Thalli for a public rally later in the day. In the evening, he will reach Chennai for a roadshow in Avadi. On the second day, Naidu will travel to Madurai and proceed to Sattlur. **OUR BUREAU**

No changes proposed to Delimitation Act, says govt

CLEARING THE AIR. ‘If passed, women’s quota will be applicable from 2029 LS polls’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government on Sunday clarified that it has no intention to modify the Delimitation Act. It has also said that the representation of the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the Scheduled Tribes (STs) will be increased after the implementation of women’s reservation.

The clarifications came in the form of a set of frequently asked questions (FAQ) after the government failed to get the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed in the Lok Sabha. Following this, it decided against proceeding with the two other bills — the Delimitation Bill and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill.

All the three bills were introduced to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha, the State assemblies and the legislative assemblies of Union Territories under the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, passed in 2023.

“No changes were proposed to the Delimitation Commission Act. The existing legal framework remains intact, and any recommendations of the Commission



BACKING OUT. After failing to secure nod for the Constitution Amendment bill, the Centre decided against proceeding with the Delimitation Bill and the UT Laws (Amendment) Bill **PTI**

would require parliamentary approval and Presidential assent,” the FAQ released by the government said. Delimitation means finalising the boundary of a constituency.

It is essential for implementing women’s reservation. The limit on seats in the Lok Sabha was set at 550 in 1976. In 1971, the population of India was 54 crore; this has now swelled to over 140 crore. Therefore, “it is important to increase seats to 850 in the Lok Sabha,” it said, while adding that this would enable fair representation for people in Parliament.

EYES ON 2029 POLLS

Explaining the rationale behind the new bills, the government said that under the

Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, reservation for women can only be implemented based on the delimitation exercise after the Census post-2026.

“If the government waits for the Census and the subsequent delimitation, women would not be able to avail of 33 per cent reservation even in the 2029 general elections, as Census and delimitation take time,” it said.

To ensure timely benefits to half the population, de-linking implementation of the Act from this condition was considered necessary, it added.

“If passed and approved, these bills would enable women to receive 33 per cent reservation in the Lok Sabha as early as the 2029 general

elections,” the Centre said. On the proposal to increase the number of seats in the Lok Sabha to 850, it said the step was based on a proportional expansion approach.

A uniform 50 per cent increase in seats would maintain the proportion for all the States and Union Territories. Applying this principle to the current 543 seats would lead to approximately 815 seats.

Therefore, the upper limit on seats was increased from the current cap of 550 seats in the Lok Sabha to 850 seats, it said.

‘NO IMPACT ON SOUTH’

Rubbishing claims that the new formula would impact the representation of the southern States, the Centre argued that, on the contrary, their overall share would remain stable.

“The southern States currently have 23.76 per cent seats in the Lok Sabha. This would have become 23.87 per cent if the Bills were passed,” it said.

Further, it clarified that ongoing elections, including in States like Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, would not be affected, as elections up to 2029 will be conducted under the current system.

This election is to save Bengal’s identity: PM Modi in Jhargram

Press Trust of India
Jhargram (WB)



A FLAIR FOR SPICE. Prime Minister Narendra Modi tries ‘jhalhuri’, a street snack made of puffed rice, on the sidelines of public meetings in Jhargram on Sunday **PTI**

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asserted that the upcoming Assembly elections in West Bengal were a battle to save the State’s identity, accusing the Mamata Banerjee government of pursuing politics that favoured “infiltrators” over the native population.

Addressing a rally in the tribal-dominated Jhargram district ahead of the April 23 elections, Modi alleged that the TMC wanted to form a “government of infiltrators and for infiltrators”, urging voters to unite to remove it from power. “This election is to save the rich heritage of this land. It is for saving the identity of Bengal. Today, there is fear of Bengal losing its identity,” he said.

Modi claimed that for such a government, the biggest obstacle would be the ordinary people of West Bengal.

Sharpening the BJP’s pitch in the tribal belt, he accused the TMC of neglecting the region despite being in power for 15 years.

“You gave 15 years to the ruthless TMC government. Fifteen years is no small amount of time. What has the TMC government given you? What have the tribal areas received? No education, no income, no medicine

and no irrigation. Everything here is in dire straits,” he alleged.

PROMISES MADE

Modi said the ‘Van Dhan Kendras’, community-owned centres to train tribals for value addition to minor forest produce, would be expanded if the BJP came to power.

He said the BJP would promote homestays and ecotourism in Jhargram, and the Centre had already taken steps to improve rail connectivity through Vande Bharat and Amrit Bharat trains.

He, however, claimed that the pace of development was being slowed by the State government.

Referring to complaints of erratic power supply in parts of Jhargram, he said people remained in darkness while

TMC leaders prospered.

Modi said the BJP, if voted to power, would ensure that electricity bills became “zero” through the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana.

The PM also warned of action against those allegedly involved in the coal scam.

He also targeted the TMC on the issue of women, accusing it of betraying its slogan of “Maa, Maati, Manush”.

Modi claimed that the BJP had sought to ensure women’s reservation from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, but the TMC opposed it in Parliament. He promised that if the BJP came to power in West Bengal, women would get ₹36,000 financial assistance annually, girls would receive ₹50,000 for graduation, and self-help groups would get assistance of up to ₹20 lakh.

IN THE LIMELIGHT



IT’S SHOWTIME. BJP leader Amit Shah with Mylapore BJP candidate Tamilisai Soundararajan (left) and Thousand Lights AIADMK candidate B Valarmathi (right) during a roadshow in Chennai ahead of the Assembly polls **BJOY GHOSH**

Congress, DMK betrayed women, says Amit Shah

Press Trust of India
Erode (Tamil Nadu)

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday lashed out at the Congress and the DMK for voting against the Constitution Amendment Bill in the Lok Sabha, accusing them of “betraying” women from getting the 33 per cent quota in Parliament and the State Assemblies.

However, Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s government will not allow the “conspiracy” to succeed and will ensure justice for the women of the country, he said.

Shah was addressing a roadshow in support of the BJP’s Modakurichi candidate, Kirthika Shivkumar, for the April 23 Assembly polls.

“There was a chance for 50 per cent [Lok Sabha] seat increase for Tamil Nadu. But they have conspired to reduce TN’s seats by insisting on their increase based on the 2026 Census,” he said.

Ahead of polls, DMK unveils ‘Chennai Super 6’ manifesto

Our Bureau
Chennai

As city infrastructure and civic amenities emerge as key issues for urban voters, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Sunday unveiled its ‘Chennai Super 6’ manifesto, promising improved civic amenities, transport upgrades and major infrastructure development.

Among the various promises for Chennai are RO purified drinking water for areas without Metro Water connections. “For residential areas with existing Metro Water access, a regular and periodic water supply will be ensured,” per the details released.

High-intensity streetlights and 1,000 new minibuses to strengthen Chennai’s connectivity and linking residential areas with transport hubs are among



Chief Minister MK Stalin releasing the ‘Chennai Super 6’ manifesto on Sunday **PTI**

the other promises. A new, unique indoor cultural centre for art, music and literary events will also be set up, it added.

Political observers view this separate manifesto for the city as an attempt by the ruling DMK to address rising

demands by the urban voter from the incumbent government.

TECH, ROADS & DOGS

The Chennai Peripheral Ring Road (from Ennore to Poonjeri) will be completed by 2027, metro rail expansion works will be completed by 2028, and construction of stormwater drains will be finished by 2028, the DMK noted in the manifesto, addressing some of the most common grievances of the city’s voters.

On the industrial front, the DMK promises to make Chennai a tech hub by setting up a specialised centre for AI, animation, visual effects, gaming and immersive technologies.

It also highlighted a solution for the stray dog menace, noting that under the animal birth control programme, the number of veterinarians and dog catchers will be tripled.

POSH complaints rise four-fold in IT firms in 5 years on better reporting

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Complaints under the Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH) framework have surged nearly four-fold across the country’s top IT services firms over the past five years, pointing less to a spike in workplace misconduct and more to a growing willingness among employees to speak up.

Data from the four large-cap firms show that reported cases, which hovered under 30 in FY21 — with Wipro as the lone outlier at 43 — climbed sharply to 444 by FY25, as per CIEL HR. Both Tata Consultancy Services and Wipro crossed the 100-mark, reporting 125 and 155 complaints respectively.

Shruti Vidyasagar, a POSH compliance lawyer, said it is more important to consider the year-on-year trend.

“There is a generational shift in terms of expectations from workplaces and a better understanding of rights. Boundaries at workplace have become very important,” said Vidyasagar.

The shift to virtual workplaces during Covid-19, as well as greater attention to POSH compliance during

the wrestler’s protest in 2023, increased employee awareness and pushed employers to take a better look at company measures to prevent such atrocities.

“Employers are putting in more effort. Clients are keen on ensuring at least once-a-year refresher sessions on these topics. More people are coming forward now,” she said, adding that there is lesser shame among companies in admitting receipt of such complaints.

NOT SIGNIFICANT

Large-cap IT services companies currently retain 2-5 lakh employees. This means that despite the growing voices, POSH complaints for each of these companies accounts for less than 1 per cent of the workforce.

Nonetheless, Vaneesha Jain, independent lawyer, Support Against Sexual Harassment (SASHA India), and legal consultant for IT firms, said there is an overall trend towards compliance among companies.

“Contracts with companies from Europe and the US require IT companies to ensure compliance with workplace safety norms,” said Nithya Rajshekhar, legal consultant, SASHA.

Weather delays summer sales, industry bets on late surge

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

After unseasonal rain in late March and early April delayed the onset of peak summer demand in several regions, makers of summer-centric products say sales are now beginning to pick up, though price hikes, particularly in air conditioners (ACs), remain a key concern.

Companies across categories such as ACs, ice-creams and beverages said intermittent rain and cooler temperatures in North, East and West India had slowed the seasonal demand cycle, even as the southern markets saw earlier traction. With forecasts pointing to a longer summer, industry players expect the core demand window to open up in the coming weeks.

SOUTH PICKS UP

For AC makers, summer remains the single-biggest driver of annual sales. While the southern region saw an early onset of summer, unseasonal rain in the northern, western and eastern regions delayed the seasonal uptick in demand.

“Southern markets are picking up. We are witnessing strong demand in Tamil



For AC makers, summer remains the single biggest driver of annual sales **REUTERS**

Nadu and seeing high double-digit growth,” said Deenadayalan C, CEO, Sathya Agencies Ltd.

Seasonal food product makers, particularly involved in making ice-creams and dairy-based beverages, said consumption trends had begun to revive after a brief weather-led slowdown.

Jayatheertha Chary, MD, Mother Dairy, said, “Summer is the most anticipated season for our value-added dairy products, and while it began on a positive note, intermittent spells of rain and relatively milder temperatures led to some short-term softening in demand across certain categories. With

temperatures now on the rise, we are witnessing a gradual revival in consumption.”

He added that given underlying consumer appetite for categories such as ice creams, curd and dairy beverages remains robust, Mother Dairy anticipates growth of over 30 per cent across key categories.

BRIEF DISRUPTION

Ice-cream makers said early signs of strong seasonal demand are already visible across formats.

“Although the full onset of summer is still not upon us, we are seeing strong traction for our portfolio of products. Overall, we are seeing broad-based growth across both impulse and take-home formats, which gives us strong confidence in the overall business outlook for the season. Categories such as cones, sticks and single-serve cups are seeing accelerated off-take, especially driven by quick commerce and immediate consumption occasions,” said Debabrata Mukherjee, MD, Havmor Ice Cream.

Beverage makers said consumption patterns had started earlier this year but were briefly disrupted by weather fluctuations.

EC action against 11,000 social media posts for violating MCC

Our Bureau
Chennai



The Election Commission has taken action against 11,000 social media posts for violating the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) and presenting misleading or unlawful content since the announcement of Assembly polls in March, the agency said in a post on X.

“In the ongoing elections for Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and West Bengal, social media content such as posts violating MCC, which disrupt or can disrupt law and order, false narratives against polling process or machinery are being monitored and acted upon by the concerned State IT Nodal Officers notified under the IT Act,” the commission added.

It also reiterated that political parties were prohibited to display any election matter for the 48-hour silence period prior to the conclusion of the poll, and

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Process deficit

Delimitation Bill fell in the absence of consultation

The defeat of the Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha raises questions about why a special session of Parliament was convened in the midst of Assembly elections to hastily pass a highly contentious Constitutional amendment. Given the sensitivity of the issue, it should’ve been obvious that such a Bill would not pass the Lok Sabha amidst elections in a couple of the very States that would be undercut by its provisions.

Yet, political calculations seem to have been behind the move as seen by how Prime Minister Narendra Modi immediately launched into the Opposition for what he called “female foeticide”. The fallen Bill was a radical departure from the existing Constitutional scheme freezing the number of seats in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies based on the 1971 census. No increase in the total number of seats can occur until the first census after 2026 is published. The 2026 Bill proposed to omit the provisions in Articles 82 and 170 that enforce this freeze. Most significantly, it proposed redefining “population” on the basis of the “population figures of the latest published census”. This would have allowed the government to use 2011 census data to increase the seats immediately. It simultaneously proposed an expansion in the number of Lok Sabha seats to 850 (815 from States and 35 from Union Territories). It then sought to amend the existing Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam — which granted 33 per cent reservation for women but explicitly stated that it would come into effect only after a delimitation exercise following the “first census taken after 2023” has been completed, a provision that pushed implementation of women’s reservation to after 2029.

One cannot argue against the Constitutional principle enshrined in Article 81(2)(a) guaranteeing “one person, one vote, one value”, which necessarily involves seat expansion on the basis of population. But there is a reason why successive governments — the last being the one led by the late Atal Bihari Vajpayee — ensured that the number of Lok Sabha seats that each State has remained frozen. It prevented the representation of five southern States from falling from 24.3 per cent to 20.7 per cent and put a stop to increase in representation of northern States by 5 per cent. The related amendments in the Constitution dictated that this arrangement would be valid until the first census after 2026. The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam in 2023 inserted Article 334A into the Constitution, linking the implementation of women’s reservation to the first census and delimitation taken after this legislation was enacted.

The government now sought to accelerate implementation by tethering women’s reservation to the 2011 Census. While constituency size needs to be adjusted for population, anxieties of southern States must be addressed. This process has to be a masterclass in trust-building. It cannot be achieved by forcing Constitutional amendments amidst an active election cycle.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Starmer and Mandelson: a story that doesn’t add up
In February, the prime minister apologised to victims of the late sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, saying he had “believed (Peter) Mandelson’s lies” before making him Britain’s ambassador to the US. By March, that account had shifted. Faced with evidence that he was warned the appointment posed a “reputational risk”, but gave the peer the job anyway, Sir Keir Starmer accepted on a trip to Belfast that he “made a mistake”. On Thursday responsibility appears to have moved again – this time on to officials. Sir Olly Robbins, the top civil servant in the Foreign Office, was forced out after the Guardian reported that Lord Mandelson had been denied security clearance for the role. No 10 said it was not told. These are not complementary explanations. They are competing ones. Either Sir Keir was misled, ignored warnings, or was failed by the system. The government’s account of the vetting process is in doubt. Ministers say warnings were overridden. But experts say that’s not how it works. LONDON, APRIL 17

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
EUROPE

Hold Off on the Iran Victory Parade
President Trump all but declared Friday as V-I Day, for Victory over Iran, but hold off on the parade. “IRAN HAS JUST ANNOUNCED THAT THE STRAIT OF IRAN IS FULLY OPEN,” he wrote Friday on Truth Social. That’s also what the April 8 U.S. cease-fire was supposed to allow. Re-opening the Strait is good news, if it happens this time, and financial markets behaved as if they think it will. Equities rose and the price of oil dropped sharply on the news, which gives the U.S. policy breathing room. NEW YORK, APRIL 18



R GOPALAN
MC SINGHI

The new national accounts, or GDP, series with 2022-23 base year raises the question of whether the deflators being used are accurate. Inaccuracies on account of the use of the wholesale price index with an outdated base year seem to persist in the new series.

The new NAS series 2022-23 uses double deflators, against single deflators in the NAS 2011-12 series. The issue of appropriate deflators, however, persists, principally on account of the WPI effect.

NAS series 2022-23, like the earlier NAS series, uses WPI and CPI as deflators for different commodities. WPI is used as deflator for over 50 per cent of NAS value added. WPI is a commodity index with base 2011-12. It has fixed basket and fixed base. It loses its representative character once it gets dated.

Various studies on Index of Industrial Production, which too has fixed base and fixed basket, have demonstrated a downward bias in growth rates once the series becomes dated. Such index series should be revised every five years and the change should become effective as early as feasible. There are no such studies for WPI because alternative measures with whom the characteristics could be compared are not available.

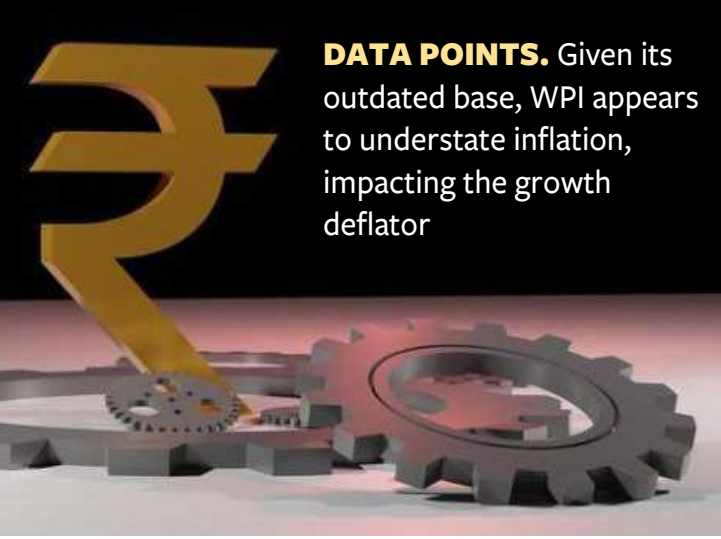
We, however, use two approaches to consider the representativeness of WPI. First, we compare the GDP deflator with sub groups of WPI and CPI since 2015-16, the year of beginning of structural changes in economy (table 1).

WPI TRENDS

WPI for all commodities has remained moderate from 2015-16 to 2020-21, the period which witnessed demonetization, GST reforms and pandemic. The GDP deflator during this period remained somewhere between WPI and CPI.

However, in 2017-18, GDP deflator was higher than both WPI and CPI; in 2018-19, it was between CPI and WPI. The deflator is perhaps influenced more by WPI for primary articles and intermediates, in relation to final products. The same appears to be true in the new series of NAS and CPI. There may be significant under-reporting of inflation for capital goods and consumer

WPI effect on new GDP series



DATA POINTS. Given its outdated base, WPI appears to understate inflation, impacting the growth deflator

J. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

goods vis-a-vis primary articles. Sticky capacity utilization confirms that product life cycle for consumer products has shortened with constant replacement. If that is correct, WPI may have become less representative.

The range of inflation for overall basket of WPI for selected years (table 2) is revealing. The number of commodities with inflation below 2 per cent increased to 447 in 2025-26 (April-February). They have a weight of around 63 per cent during 2015-2021, the years of structural volatility, much higher than in last two years or earlier period from 2013-2022. A similar bias appears in 2025-26. This points to the fact that commodity composition is gradually shifting away from being representative with decline in response rate, or a repeat of previous quotations.

INFLATION DYNAMICS

The increasing number of commodities with negative inflation may be largely due to the product having ceased to report. The new GDP series (2022-23) also coincides with an increase in number of commodities with inflation higher than the benchmark range of RBI under inflation targeting.

Yet, during April February 2025-26, 526 commodities having weight of 93

Sticky capacity utilization confirms that product life cycle for consumer products has shortened with constant replacement. If that is correct, WPI may have become less representative

West Asia crisis and fertilizer management

In a situation of war-induced supply shock in fertilizers, farmers must be nudged towards pulses and oilseeds

A Narayanamoorthy

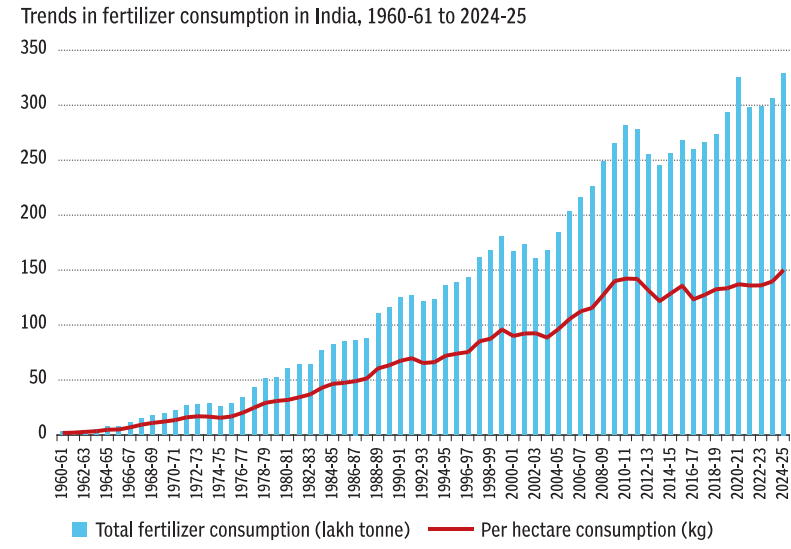
Fertilizer shortage looms large in the wake of the West Asia war, given our heavily reliance on the region for fertilizer and feedstock. This leads to the issue of addressing scarcity in the upcoming kharif season.

The legacy of the Green Revolution has been the manifold increase in our reliance on chemical fertilizers, propelling India as the second-largest consumer of these nutrients in the world. The scale of this transition is staggering. Total fertilizer (NPK) consumption surged to 32.93 million tonnes (mt) in 2024-25, a massive leap from a mere 0.295 mt in 1960-61. On a per-hectare basis, the consumption has skyrocketed from 1.92 kg to 150.11 kg, an increase of over 78 times (see Chart).

While domestic production has followed a positive trajectory, reaching an all-time high of 21.95 mt in 2023-24, our dependence on the Gulf region remains a critical vulnerability. Gulf countries together account for approximately 30 per cent of India’s imports of both urea and di-ammonium phosphate (DAP). Further, about 50 per cent of our Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) is sourced from this region. Since LNG is the primary feedstock for urea production, any disruption in the Gulf region directly affects Indian agriculture.

Following the disruption, the daily production of urea reportedly plummeted by 30,000-35,000 tonnes from its normal level of 80,000 tonnes. Recognising the situation, the government has taken steps to help boost daily production to 67,000 tonnes. However, this recovery has come at a

On the rise



Source: Agricultural Statistics at a Glance, Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, New Delhi

high cost, as it relies on expensive spot-market gas purchases to bridge the supply gap.

The timing is particularly crucial as we approach the kharif season. During 2025, total fertilizer sales reached 36.1 mt, comprising 19.32 mt of urea, 4.63 mt of DAP, 1.1 mt of MOP, 8.15 mt of complex fertilizers and others. For 2026, the demand is projected at 39 mt. This demand could increase further if the country receives a normal monsoon and paddy area expands beyond last year’s level. While the government is making every effort to bolster production, the risk of panic buying before the onset of the season in June is a real concern that must be seriously addressed.

REMEDIAL MEASURES

Reports suggest that the damage to production units of key feedstock in the Gulf region is extensive, implying that supply chains will not normalise immediately. In this context, several remedial measures are essential to safeguard our farmers and ensure food security.

Foremost, farmers must be advised to use fertilizers judiciously across all crops. Currently, paddy and wheat together consume about 56 per cent of the total urea supply. Encouraging a shift towards pulses and oilseeds, which require significantly less fertilizer, could alleviate the pressure on nitrogenous supplies. To facilitate this transition, the government should consider providing

short-term incentives on per hectare basis to farmers who move away from fertilizer-intensive paddy and wheat cultivation. To address the anticipated fertilizer shortage, the government has reportedly issued advisories to States recommending SSP (single superphosphate) and TSP (triple superphosphate) as effective substitutes for DAP. These alternatives must now be proactively promoted to farmers particularly in Punjab, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, where the intensity of fertilizer consumption is high.

The current application of nutrients is deeply skewed. Instead of the scientifically recommended NPK ratio of 4:2:1, the actual ratio followed by farmers in 2023-24 was 11.6:4.6:1. This excessive use of urea not only leads to diminishing returns in soil fertility but also triggers widespread micro-nutrient deficiencies. Fixing this imbalance through the area-based rationing of fertilizer supply may reduce the scarcity of urea.

PROMOTE NANO-UREA

Furthermore, the promotion of nano-urea is no longer an option but a necessity. Nano-urea increases nutrient efficiency while significantly reducing the fiscal burden on the state and the logistics of transport. Moving towards more efficient delivery systems, alongside an aggressive promotion of organic farming and Zero Budget Natural Farming will help reduce our long-term dependency on chemical imports.

The writer is an economist and former full-time Member (Official), Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices, New Delhi. Views expressed are personal

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Gold investment

This refers to ‘The golden trade is not yet crowded’ (April 19). The article makes several sophisticated points that differentiate the “dip” from a “crash”. Comparing them via ratios is effective because it highlights extremes. However, a note of caution may be warranted when comparing gold with equities. The two differ fundamentally in nature — equities are linked to earnings and growth, while gold largely serves as a store of value and a hedge in uncertain times. Their price movements are driven by distinct factors, and the relationship between them is neither stable nor

consistently inverse across cycles. Hence, direct comparisons or relative valuation approaches may at times lead to oversimplified conclusions. Gold may be better viewed as a complementary asset within a diversified portfolio rather than an alternative to equities.

J Kumar
Srirangam (TN)

A fatal inertia

India is currently a furnace. With mercury levels breaching 45°C, we are witnessing a systemic collapse masked as seasonal weather. This isn’t just a heatwave it’s a preview of an uninhabitable future.

While the vulnerable perish in 40°C+ zones our urban planning remains archaic favouring concrete over canopy. To survive States must mandate Urban Heat Action Plans and no-work zones for outdoor labourers. Statistically every ₹1 invested in cooling infrastructure saves ₹4 in healthcare costs. We cannot shield ourselves with umbrellas against a climate we’ve set on fire. Unless States pivot to aggressive green infrastructure they aren’t managing weather they are managing a graveyard. Governments must subsidise high albedo cool roofs, enforce strict

reforestation quotas and overhaul power grids to support decentralised renewable cooling for all.

Vijaykumar H K
Raichur

Build consensus

The defeat of the Constitutional amendment on women’s reservation in the Lok Sabha, linked to seat expansion and fresh delimitation after a prolonged freeze, marks a significant moment in Parliamentary democracy. It underscores the ability of a united Opposition to articulate concerns and influence legislative outcomes.

For the government, this represents an unusual setback. While it may continue to project its commitment to women’s empowerment, the failure to secure passage of its own Bill points to the limits of pursuing major reforms without adequate consultation and consensus-building. The episode highlights the importance of dialogue and institutional integrity in advancing transformative legislation. It is imperative that future efforts are guided by inclusiveness and respect for democratic processes.

M Jeyaram
Sholavandan (TN)

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

The past fortnight, apparel firms sashayed down the brand runway with compelling films showcasing their Spring-Summer collections and fashion ethos

Ballooning up

Paint brand Kansai Nerolac put its product through a stratospheric test! It launched a balloon up to 86,000 ft above the Earth. The balloon carried a payload painted with Kansai Nerolac's Excel Everlast to demonstrate how it would hold up at temperatures below -64°C and at an altitude where UV radiation is completely unfiltered. The paint came back unblemished. The extreme paint test was the idea of creative agency ULKA. The #OutOfThisWorld campaign film documents the journey of the payload as it rises to the stratosphere and returns intact, showcasing a paint engineered to outlast some of the harshest conditions.

Global transitions

WforWoman, the premium contemporary Indian-wear brand from the house of Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Limited, has launched an AI-generated film that captures vignettes from its participation at the recently concluded Paris Fashion Week (PFW). The digital film opens on a quiet Parisian morning, soft light spilling across the city and gently revealing W's Spring-Summer 2026 collection. Through seamless, unhurried transitions, we see a woman first at a café, and then moving through a calm day until it gives way to the energy of the runway at the PFW in the evening.

Conscious wear

Fashion-tech brand Virgio's latest ad campaign is centred on clean fashion, positioning it as a defining cultural shift in how fashion is perceived, created and consumed today. The campaign unfolds across traditional media, creator-led content and cultural conversations. It reframes conscious fashion as an advantage, not a compromise, and presents clean fashion as a way of dressing that reflects both personal style and values, aligning with a generation that seeks clarity, intention and authenticity in what they wear.

Pachisi ride

Breaking the clutter of IPL season ads, which are typically dominated by big-budget productions featuring cricketers, Uber takes a different route for its bike rides. To ram home the fact that Uber Bike rides start at just ₹25 (up to 3 km), the brand has rolled out sharp, high-energy films with Indian hip-hop artists Divine (Mumbai) and Roll Rida (Hyderabad). Divine is seen zipping through traffic on an Uber Bike in his signature style, sporting metal grills in his teeth and matching rings and jacket. He raps about the 'pachisi' (₹25 rides to beat traffic) leading to Uber 'battisi' (hip-hop lingo for wide, 32-teeth smiles).

Bhidu explains

Atomberg India's campaign film for its adaptive water purifier features Jackie Shroff in his inimitable 'Bhidu' act trying to explain the features of the product. The adaptive purification system intelligently selects RO, UV or UF modes based on the total dissolved solids (TDS) level, ensuring safe water while retaining essential minerals and avoiding unnecessary RO usage. Shroff keeps fluffing his lines when encountering terms like TDS. Through the comic banter between the director and actor, technical details about the product are simplified, making it easy to understand and shareable.

NUGGETS.

Weaving together

Two D2C brands that have been taking the six yards places are coming together in a strategic union to scale up Indian handloom artisanship. Shobitam, co-founded by sisters Aparna and Ambika, has acquired Kalaneca, also co-founded by sisters (twins in this case) Ramya and Kavea R Chavali, and which has been working on the revival of the exquisite Uppada Jamdani saree. It's an interesting union as Shobitam has built a global community of saree shoppers — from Chennai to California. And Kalaneca has, over the last 12 years, become synonymous with Uppada sarees, promoting the weave through saree soirees and a CEO Club collection. "As a brand that was born for Uppada, this synergy comes at a crucial time to take the storytelling to a global scale," says Kavea. Expressing her elation at the deal, Ramya says the Kalaneca identity will remain intact and the beauty of Uppada sarees will get a global audience.

BRAIN TEASERS

How creators are making curiosity cool

TRIVIA TESTS. Can marketers leverage the growing popularity of quizfluencers and trivia content creators to build brands?

Chitra Narayanan

Turn to Instagram and scroll through the inevitable food, beauty and entertainment reels, the cats and dogs content and, suddenly, the algorithm seems to be shifting. Popping up more and more frequently are fun quizzes and trivia tests by both global and Indian creators. For instance, handles like @thedropapinshow and @bradythetutor test your knowledge about countries in the most entertaining way. Closer home, there are handles like @AreyPata-Hai, run by Mohit Mamoria and Nipun Jain, @abhiandniyu, run by Abhiraj Rajadhyaksha and Niyati Mavinkurve, and @kk.create, run by Kavya Karnatac, that flood you with interesting facts and trivia. And as you consume more of this content, suddenly the algorithm throws at you handles like @2Bunkers, where saree retailers Nasir Iqbal and Kasif Iqbal come up with all sorts of questions about the six-yard drape. Knowledge is showing up in new formats. And curiosity has become very cool, thanks to smart creators on the Internet. Ace quizzier Joy Bhattacharjya agrees. He says, "Social media has definitely given a fillip to quizzing, because it is the best vehicle to reach new and focused audiences.



FUN FACT. Mohit Mamoria and Nipun Jain, Co-founders of @AreyPataHai

Folks not interested in quizzing in general might just be up for a trivia session on the IPL or Harry Potter or BTS. And those specific audiences often enjoy extending that to landing up for a pub quiz on the same in their city." Brand consultant Giraj Sharma, founder of Behind the Moon, also points to how quizzing is now growing both in the digital and physical world. Trivia game nights,

a very American phenomenon, is now seen at places like Monkey Bar and Social as a way of boosting foot-falls and engagement. In nostalgia-filled sessions, diners get quizzed on cult movies or music bands or sports. A conversation with @AreyPata-Hai's Mamoria on the rise of quizzing is illuminating. Mamoria is riding high after his trivia-packed book, *What the... What?!*, written with Jain and published by

SOAPS AND SUDS

ITC Fiama is lathering up its premium reach

Mithun Dasgupta

ITC's premium personal-care brand Fiama aspires to hit ₹1,000 crore revenue within two years, from ₹750-800 crore at present. The brand, launched as Fiama di Wills in 2007 with a shampoo range, has maintained over 20 per cent CAGR over the last five years, growing across urban and rural markets. Starting off as a personal care experiment for the tobacco major, the brand's impressive growth makes for an interesting case study. With over 3,000 brands and around 3,500 varieties, soap is the largest personal care category in India, valued around ₹26,000 crore. It is challenging for any new brand to break into this highly penetrated market and turn both sustainable and profitable. It's an even greater challenge for a premium soap. Over the years, brand Fiama (it dropped di Wills along the way) has been built to be vibrant and youthful. "We created a very different emotional promise. ITC positioned

the entire Fiama brand on the concept of the joy of bathing," says Sameer Satpathy, Chief Executive of ITC's Personal Care Products Division. "There are two parts to a bath — one is focused on the quality of your skin and skincare, and the second is the freshness and enjoyment you get out of the daily routine. Both are important to consumers. One is more short-term, while the other is long-term. Fiama positioned itself uniquely to balance both the bathing needs," he explains. The brand's marquee product, besides shower gels, is the gel bar it created in 2009 using a proprietary liquid crystal freezing technology — a first of its kind globally — supported by the ITC Life Science and Technology Centre in Bengaluru. "The whole idea was to offer something distinctly different, superior and interesting as opposed to anything that was already in the market," Satpathy says. The brand targets the "young at heart" — consumers who value their daily shower as a three-minute "dose of happiness" before they get ready for the world, says Satpathy.



BATHED IN LUXURY. Fiama is an ₹800 crore premium personal-care brand

It then launched a multi-variant soap pack — from peach and avocado to lemongrass and jojoba, and patchouli and macadamia. "Young consumers want variety. We were able to package a wide variety into one pack... This came from the insight that people tend to buy different soaps when they go shopping. This was also one of the reasons we were able to make great inroads into the market," Satpathy says. Fiama products are manufactured across ITC's three integrated

units — at Haridwar in Uttarakhand, Baddi in Himachal Pradesh, and a new digitally-enabled factory near Kolkata. INNOVATION LINE-UP A recent innovation is its Japanese Hokkaido milk soap range in variants like blueberry, goji berry and acai berry — which, it says, offer high moisturisation without the stickiness of cream-based soaps. Satpathy says the brand maintains a steady innovation pipeline

with two to three launches per year. On Amazon, the brand has just launched Hokkaido milk body scrubs in two variants — papain and niacinamide. It previously launched a range of shower gels, loofas and handwashes. "We launched as a premium brand even before premiumisation was a significant trend. With a strong innovation pipeline and robust portfolio strategy, we have ensured that the brand remains relevant and exciting for consumers. This is evident from the encouraging market standing and continued consumer love that the brand has achieved over the years," Satpathy says. Ask brand strategist Ambi MG Parameswaran, who has worked on soap brands like Santoor, about his views on Fiama and he says, "The premium soap segment is not very large in India and it is difficult to build a large credible brand in the segment. Dove and Pears literally rule the roost, at least in modern trade. Fiama has stayed the course and managed to build a good customer base, largely based on its product formulation, packaging and fragrance." Can it raise the bar further?

Iran just won the (meme) war

The Iranian social media campaign has proved that volume isn't the same as wit, and reach isn't the same as resonance

DIGITAL GADFLY



SHUBHO SENGUPTA

On February 28, the US and Israel bombed Iran. Within 24 hours, Iran was already winning a different war. Not with missiles. With memes. Before the smoke had cleared, accounts linked to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) flooded social media with propaganda reaching millions. News-Guard, a media watchdog, tracked 50 false claims in the first 25 days — 92 per cent pro-Iranian. The ROI was instant — by mid-March, 58 per cent of Americans were against the strikes. Iran had walked into the American living room and started rearranging the furniture. None of this was improvised, unlike a Miles Davis riff. The Supreme Leader Khamenei said it himself in 2024: "The media is more effective than missiles, planes and drones in forcing the enemy to retreat." So, the new generation of Iranian propagandists grew up online (while pursuing PhDs — dudes are highly educated, as we know by now). They make Lego animations, rap diss tracks, *Teletubbies* parodies. They know the Epstein files. They know *The Apprentice*. Their frame isn't classic Islamic resistance — it's US counterculture. Trump's own *Apprentice* catch-

Let's deep-dive into the Top 3 memes. #1 The Lego Epstein video Trump and Netanyahu hunch over a folder marked 'Epstein Files'. A red devil Lego hovers behind them, golden goblet raised. They hit a button. An Iranian school gets bombed. The camera holds on what's left: A small pair of shoes and a school bag in the rubble. Then Iran strikes back — US bases, Ben Gurion airport, a Dubai hotel. Iranian soldiers charge. Credits. Within a month, Explosive Media — aka AkhbarEnfejari, Explosive News — had millions of views. They call themselves a "student-led media team". The BBC found the Iranian government was allegedly a paying client. The master stroke was the Epstein hook. Epstein wasn't an Iranian issue — he was a pre-existing American wound about power and impunity. Iran didn't need to explain geopolitics. The audience already had the shame, the feelings. Iran just pointed. #2 "Hey, Trump. You Are Fired." No AI. No budget. Just Brigadier General Ebrahim Zolfaghari staring into a camera like he was waiting his whole career for the moment. Persian. Then English. "Hey, Trump. You are fired. You are familiar with this sentence. Thank you for your attention to this matter." Trump's own *Apprentice* catch-



TON OF BRICKS. Iranian infowar launched from Legoland PHOTO CREDIT: YOUTUBE

phrase, returned to sender by a uniformed general, mid-war. Zolfaghari — previously a nobody — went global overnight. He's since renamed Operation Epic Fury as "Epic Fear" and noted that wars are decided "in the field, not by tweets." Zero deniability. The Iranian State, on record, doing comedy. The smirk was a strategic asset. #3 The Strait of Hormuz key Possibly the funniest thing any government has done on social media. Trump ultimatum: "Reopen the strait by April 7". Iranian embassy in Zimbabwe: "Sorry, lost the key." Deadline passed. Embassy: "We found the key." Iranian embassy in South Africa: "Eish, eventually. I told you it was under the flower pot, lazy." An Indian X user asked Iran's Mumbai consulate if it was hiring.

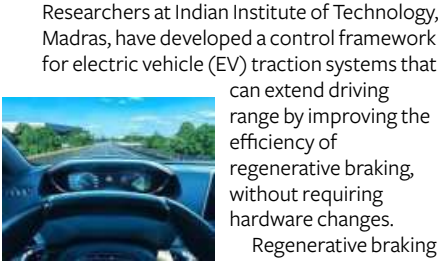
Consulate: "No vacancies. Our team is all Iranian — with a soft spot for India — though bringing our Indian friends onboard someday is a pretty great idea." Massive hit in India. The "soft spot" line wasn't just flattery — it carried decades of history (India-Iran history — those who know, know) in a joke, from a consulate to a country not even in the war. That's not social media. That's cutting-edge diplomacy. Also: The White House posts Trump as Jesus. Iran posts Trump as the Epstein guy. How does a sanctions-hit, internet-blackout country produce the most viral propaganda operation of the century? There are three layers. Official: IRGC-affiliated media, State embassies, Explosive Media and other studios. Covert: Fake personas — Latin

women in Texas, Scottish independence supporters — building real audiences for months, maybe years. On February 28, 61 accounts switched simultaneously to pro-Iran war content. One switch. Zero organic. Amplification: Russia and China boosting at scale, turning a regional operation global. It works because of the information void. Both sides have censored the conflict. Nobody knows what's happening on the ground. Iran floods that vacuum with AI content that's fast, emotional, shareable. Doesn't need to be true. Needs to feel true for four seconds. The deeper irony: Iran learned this from Trump. He built his career on catchphrases, insults, and contempt for dignified communication. Iran watched, took notes and is now running his playbook back at him — better writers; clearer, sharper villain; audience already softened, primed. Political IT cells everywhere — factories of WhatsApp forwards and outrage bait running 24/7 — are watching from the sidelines. The Iran campaign has proved that volume isn't the same as wit, and reach isn't the same as resonance. The difference is the joke, the humour. Iran's memes make even critics laugh. IT cell memes die early deaths. They have a lot of catching up to do. *Lagey rahlo*, Munnabhai.

Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past

FROM THE LABS.

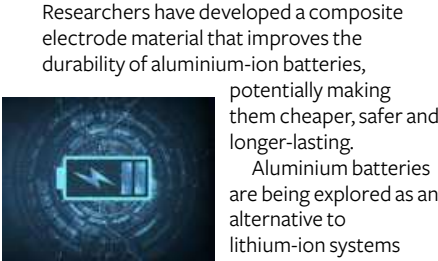
Efficient brakes and EV range



Researchers at Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, have developed a control framework for electric vehicle (EV) traction systems that can extend driving range by improving the efficiency of regenerative braking, without requiring hardware changes. Regenerative braking allows EVs to recover energy during deceleration, but it becomes ineffective below a certain speed. In most systems, this low-speed cut-off is fixed using empirical methods that do not adapt to operating conditions, leading to energy loss. The IIT-Madras team addresses this by introducing an analytical method to determine the speed below which regenerative braking should be disabled. It is derived from first principles and computed offline, avoiding additional computational load during real-time vehicle operation.

In addition, the researchers developed a model-based algorithm that dynamically adjusts the motor's magnetic flux depending on speed and torque conditions. This replaces conventional fixed-flux operation, reducing power losses and extending the effective range over which regenerative braking can function. The framework has been tested using both international and Indian driving cycles, including the modified Indian drive cycle (MIDC). Results show a reduction in traction system losses of up to 13 per cent under MIDC conditions and about 7 per cent under the US EPA highway cycle. The paper, published in the journal *IEEE Transactions on Transportation Electrification*, was co-authored by research scholar MK Deepa, Prof Srikanthan Sridharan and Prof CS Shankar Ram. The team plans to test the framework on full-scale EVs to assess system-level effects, including battery performance and thermal behaviour, and explore its integration with battery state-of-charge management.

Stable aluminium-ion battery



Researchers have developed a composite electrode material that improves the durability of aluminium-ion batteries, potentially making them cheaper, safer and longer-lasting. Aluminium batteries are being explored as an alternative to lithium-ion systems because aluminium is abundant, inexpensive and can store more charge per atom. However, poor durability is a major hindrance: The electrode material tends to crack or dissolve into the electrolyte during repeated charging and discharging cycles, leading to rapid loss of performance. A commonly used cathode material, vanadium oxide, can store high energy and allows aluminium ions to move through its layered structure. But in water-based aluminium batteries, it dissolves into the electrolyte, causing the battery to lose capacity quickly. To address this, a team led by Kavita Pandey at the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences, working with researchers from the Shiv Nadar Institution of Eminence, combined vanadium oxide with MXene, a highly conductive, ultra-thin material. In this composite, MXene forms a conductive network that stabilises the vanadium oxide and provides smooth pathways for ion movement. "This significantly reduces the dissolution of vanadium into the electrolyte — from 28.3 ppm in pure vanadium oxide to 5.4 ppm in the composite," says a press release. As a result, battery performance improves markedly. The composite retains over 73 per cent of its original capacity after 100 charge cycles and about 59 per cent even after 500 cycles, substantially better than conventional designs. Further analysis showed that the MXene framework helps preserve the electrode's structure during operation, preventing the cracks and damage that typically degrade aluminium-ion batteries.

● GREEN SMELTER

Half the capex, less carbon: The molten magic inside Tata Steel's Hisarna bet

NEX-GEN PROCESS. Based on the new technology, planned new ₹4,000-crore plant in Jamshedpur is set to be pathbreaking

M Ramesh

It costs about a billion dollars (₹9,000 crore) to set up a steel plant with a capacity of one million tonnes. But Tata Steel is planning one at Jamshedpur for roughly ₹4,000 crore.

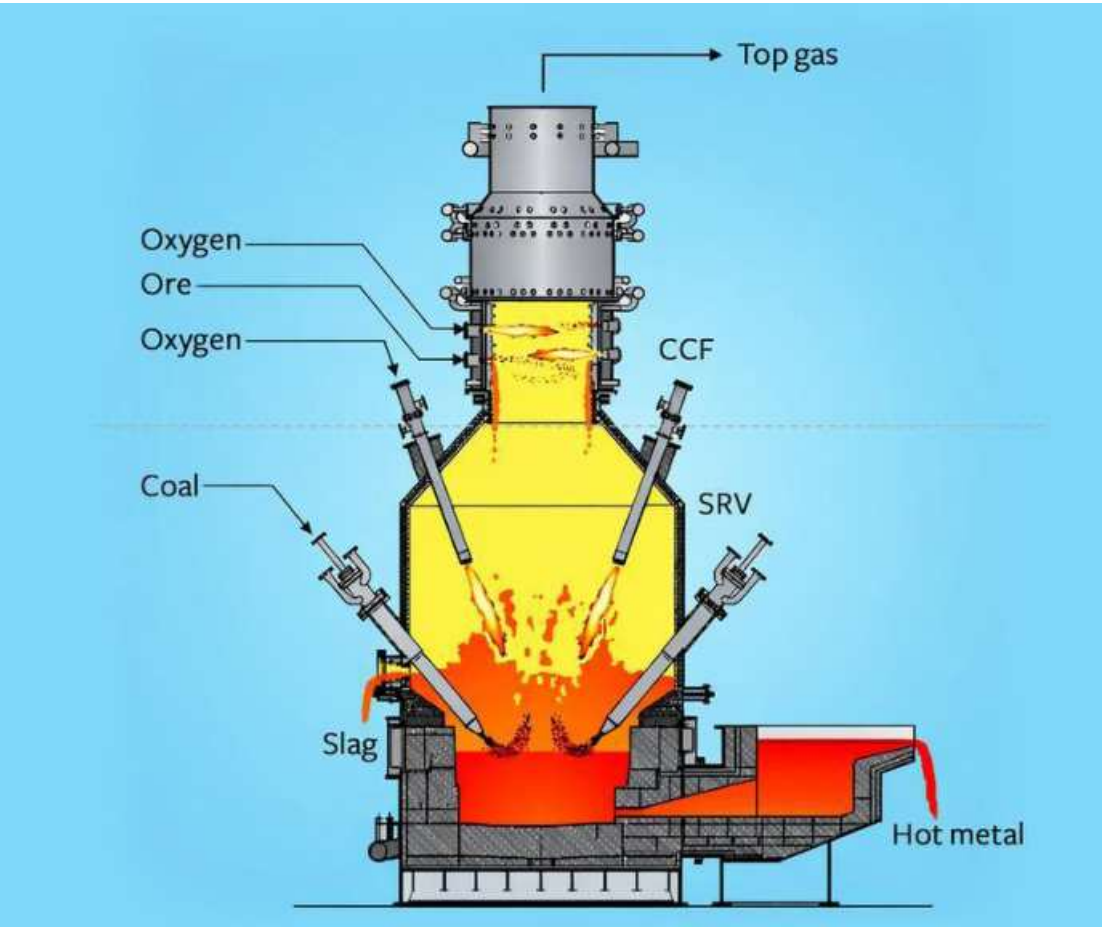
This is magic made possible by an entirely new steel-making process — Hisarna. Tata Steel had a big hand in its development and now owns the patent.

Hisarna has the potential to revolutionise steel making — once perfected in a commercial plant, it is expected to elbow out all other conventional methods of steel making, such as blast furnace or electric arc furnace.

Its advantages are striking. First, it eliminates two unavoidable steps in traditional steel-making processes — coke-making and the agglomeration of iron ore (into sinter or pellets). That alone knocks off chunks of capital cost. Second, Hisarna doesn't care about ore quality — low-grade iron ore, abundantly available in eastern India, works just as well. Third, carbon dioxide emissions are estimated to be about 20 per cent lower than in a conventional plant of comparable size. Moreover, the carbon dioxide stream is relatively pure, making carbon capture easier and cheaper, without any need for separation from other flue gases.

How does Hisarna achieve this? The answer lies in its architecture.

Leaving aside the minutiae, the Hisarna furnace has two chambers, one above the other. Powdered iron ore is injected into the top chamber, where it spirals downward. The spiralling keeps it longer in the chamber, which is essential. The



powder injection is also the technology's biggest challenge: The iron ore particles must neither fly out nor fall straight through.

Non-coking coal is injected into the lower, smelting vessel. Oxygen is introduced at multiple points. The coal reacts with oxygen to produce carbon monoxide (CO), which rises to the top chamber. There it meets oxygen again, burns into carbon dioxide, and releases intense

heat. This heat melts the ore, which then drips into the lower chamber.

Iron ore (ferric oxide or Fe₂O₃) must be reduced — its oxygen removed — to yield iron. In Hisarna, this happens in two stages. In the upper chamber, ferric oxide is partly reduced to ferrous oxide (FeO) as it encounters the rising CO and injected oxygen; the heat generated also melts the ore. The molten ferrous oxide then falls into

the lower chamber, where it reacts with the carbon in coal. The oxygen bonds with carbon, leaving behind molten iron. The outputs are liquid iron and a relatively pure stream of carbon dioxide.

LIGHT FOOTPRINT

The process can use low-grade ore, which would otherwise be discarded. The plant footprint is about half that of a comparable blast fur-

nace setup. The slag can go straight into a cement kiln, unlike the blast furnace slag. Taken together, these factors could lower operating costs by around 10 per cent, according to Subodh Pandey, Vice-President (Technology, R&D, NMB and Graphene) at Tata Steel. The Hisarna plant in Jamshedpur is expected to go on stream by 2030.

How did Tata Steel get here? "Perseverance," says Pandey — and there's a story behind that.

The idea of a new steel-making route was first pursued in Europe under the Ultra-Low CO₂ Steel-making (ULCOS) initiative, a consortium of 48 companies. One of them was Koninklijke Hoogovens, which later merged with British Steel to form Corus Group and was acquired by Tata Steel in 2007.

The construction of a pilot plant in the Netherlands began in 2010, followed by years of trials. Rio Tinto, the British-Australian mining major, joined in 2011, bringing its Hismelt technology (the bottom chamber). Tata Steel acquired the technology from Rio Tinto in 2017.

Initially, there were many setbacks — refractories failed, operations proved unstable — and most partners lost interest. In 2021, Tata Steel, along with US company Nucor, revived the effort with new operating protocols. The results improved. "We have reached higher operating capacity than originally planned: 14 tonnes of ore per hour against 12 tonnes," Pandey says.

Perseverance paid off for Tata Steel — in results and in patents. For Nucor, which largely produces steel from scrap, Hisarna offers a route to higher-end products that are not easily made via scrap. Nucor holds rights to build a Hisarna plant in the US, subject to a licence fee — and intends to do so.

● WOW. Cosmic aid for miners



M Ramesh

Mineral prospecting involves a good amount of punting. Determining where the drill bit hits the ground is largely educated guesswork. Now, there is help coming to strengthen this guesswork — and it is coming from the skies. In the future, when mining engineers set out to locate mineral ores hidden deep inside the earth, they will have assistance from an unlikely quarter — space.

Exploding stars — supernovae — send streams of protons across space; some of them reach earth's atmosphere, collide with particles and turn into 'muons'. According to the US Department of Energy, one muon hits every sq cm of the earth every minute. Muons live for microseconds, but that is enough for them to

plough through the ground. Their trajectories depend on the density and atomic composition of the material they traverse, a property that is used to generate 3D images of the structures they penetrate.

Muon tomography, a decades-old technique back in business today thanks to improved sensors and computing, is being sought after by mining companies. Rio Tinto, BHP and NexGen (a uranium miner) have all signed up for the services of Canadian company Ideon Technologies to access 'subsurface intelligence'.

A recent paper by two researchers at the University of Texas notes that muon tomography has already demonstrated effectiveness in diverse applications. Other than mineral prospecting, the technique can be used to detect, for example, hidden nuclear material, the researchers say.

● SMART UTILITY

When the grid becomes an all-knowing data system



N Nagaraj

The transition to renewable energy is re-making India's power grid at a level that generation capacity figures do not capture. Integrating variable solar and wind power at scale requires continuous, real-time data exchange between generation sources, storage systems and grid operators. Battery storage must respond to grid signals within milliseconds.

Demand response, peer-to-peer energy trading and distributed generation require the grid to function as an information system. Each of these capabilities connects what engineers call operational technology to information networks.

The equipment that manages voltage, frequency and power flow, previously isolated from external networks by design, is now networked by operational requirement. Every new connection extends the boundary of what is reachable from outside.

The draft National Electricity Policy (NEP), 2026, addresses this through two provisions that pull against each other. Section 12 mandates that all infrastructure and control systems storing or processing power sector

data should be physically located within India, explicitly including battery management systems. Section 13 requires the same sectoral entities to share their operational and market data under regulatory safeguards to enable AI applications, analytics and innovation. Territorial control over the data layer is the objective of one; circulation of that data is the objective of the other. The India Energy Stack, named in Section 7 as a foundational framework for interoperable energy systems and financial settlements, is the architecture intended to hold both requirements together.

Battery management systems illustrate how the security logic works at the component level. A battery management system continuously monitors cell behaviour: Charge and discharge rates, thermal conditions, capacity degradation and grid response characteristics. For a grid-scale installation, this data constitutes a detailed operational profile of critical infrastructure across a range of conditions, including emergencies. The mandate to keep this data within Indian jurisdiction is a security measure

embedded in technical specification: Operational intelligence on grid behaviour under stress cannot be routed to servers outside Indian control.

The supervisory control and data acquisition systems running India's load despatch centres present a structurally difficult problem. These are continuous operational systems managing live grid infrastructure, sourced from vendors including ABB, Siemens and GE Vernova. NEP 2026 proposes that the Grid Controller of India Limited and State load despatch centres endeavour to transition to indigenously developed systems by 2030. The transition requires replacing live control systems on infrastructure that cannot be taken offline, against a four-year timeline, with a domestic software and hardware supply chain that does not yet exist at the required scale or reliability.

The policy's governing logic is clear: Open at the data layer, sovereign at the infrastructure layer. The India Energy Stack is expected to be the framework that will operationalise this principle.

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

● BIO-METALLURGY

Micro-mining for critical rare earth minerals

A sustainable, low-carbon extraction process taps electronic waste and industrial byproducts

K Bharat Kumar

Rare earth elements (REEs) are critical to the manufacture and working of electric vehicles, wind turbines and defence equipment. However, mining for these minerals harms the environment, not to mention the lack of mature and patented refining processes in India, unlike in China.

Enter bio-metallurgy — namely the recovery of metals using microbes. It is a sustainable, low-carbon means of extracting critical rare earth minerals from sources such as electronic waste and industrial byproducts.

The recovery process typically involves several biological steps. In bioleaching, microbes make metals soluble with the aid of molecules such as siderophores and lanthanophores, or dissolve them through the secretion of organic acids.

Biosorption is the process in which living or dead microbial bio-

mass acts as a 'sponge' — negatively charged functional groups on cell walls trap positively charged REE ions.

The discovery of the protein lanmodulin has helped ramp up the ability to selectively weed out REE minerals, since it has 100 million times more affinity for REEs than common metals such as calcium.

UNLIKELY FEEDSTOCK

Research has shown that laterite and coal/lignite mines are good sources of REEs. These deposits contain REE in way higher concentrations than land surface. A Cornell University study identifies microbes that offer dual benefit — harvesting REEs while capturing atmospheric carbon dioxide.

Certain bacteria use carbon dioxide to build biomass, secreting the acids required for leaching while permanently fixing the carbon into organic matter. These successes, achieved under lab conditions, may require more testing and proofs of



concept before transferring to the real world.

A consortium of microbes is seen to be 20 per cent more effective at dissolving magnets than single strains. Growing microbes in a nutrient-rich environment before adding waste prevents metal toxicity, allowing for higher processing densities. The biological process requires 90 per cent less energy than traditional smelting, and uses cheap 'fuels' such as elemental sulphur.

For India, these advancements are essential to help cut the dependence on imports for REEs.

The side effects of mining include toxic orange water or acid

mine drainage which, together with other unsafe byproducts such as coal ash, can be transformed into a resource refinery for high-purity REE magnets.

Akhilesh Bagaria, Co-founder of NavPrakriti, a company that mines discarded batteries for materials, says 'bio-hydrometallurgy' is the next frontier in extracting value from waste. "Integrating biological processes like bioleaching with established hydrometallurgical techniques isn't just about cutting emissions" but also changing how we extract value from waste.

The company is exploring collaborations with research institutions to adapt microbial technologies for Indian conditions.

Will his company adopt bio-filters such as lanmodulin? "For India, where strategic resource recovery is critical, these bio-based filters could redefine standards for purity and efficiency. NavPrakriti sees real potential for adapting them to local industrial processes," Bagaria says.

GLOBAL BYTES.

IATA flags potential jet fuel shortage

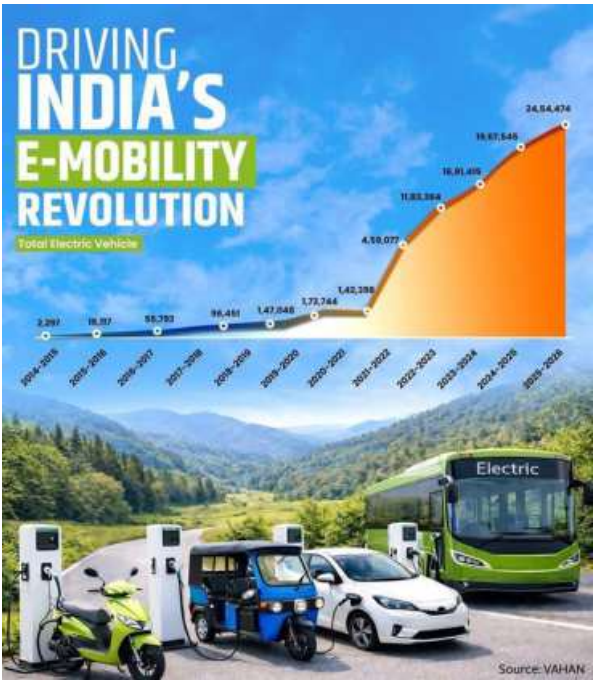
International Air Transport Association Director General Willie Walsh has voiced concerns over potential jet fuel shortages and cancellations in Europe by end-May. “The IEA’s (International Energy Agency) assessment of potential jet fuel shortages is sobering. We have also estimated that by the end of May we could start to see some cancellations in Europe for lack of jet fuel. This is already happening in parts of Asia. Along with doing everything possible to secure alternative supply lines, it’s important that authorities have well-communicated and well-coordinated plans in place, in case rationing becomes necessary, including for slot relief,” said Walsh.

A month of contrasts for Cathay Pacific

Cathay Chief Customer and Commercial Officer Lavinia Lau said, “March was a month of contrasts. On the one hand, the ongoing situation in the Middle East shifted demand towards other aviation hubs and generated robust volumes on our flights. On the other hand, the price of jet fuel has increased significantly since the start of March and this is placing huge cost pressure on airlines around the world.” According to data published by the International Air Transport Association, the global average jet fuel price has increased to \$197.83 per barrel for the week ending April 10 versus \$99.4 for the week ending February 27, Cathay Pacific stated.

New rules to streamline ship registration

The International Maritime Organisation’s legal committee has approved a new set of guidelines to improve transparency and due diligence in ship registration, as well as prevent fraudulent registrations and misuse of flags. The guidelines help close a key regulatory gap for the maritime industry, given there is currently no binding international framework to regulate the registration of ships. The newly approved guidelines will assist new and existing flag State ship registries by providing practical measures to strengthen verification and due diligence, ensure accurate ownership records and improve oversight of registration procedures.



RE POSTS.

- ✕** Advancing Airside Excellence

The newly built Parallel Taxi Track (PTT) and Rapid Exit Taxiway (RET) at Bhubaneswar Airport @aai**bp**airport have been successfully operationalised, marking a significant milestone in enhancing airside efficiency.

These upgrades will reduce runway occupancy time, enable faster aircraft movement, and minimise delays—ensuring a smoother and more reliable travel experience for passengers.

Airports Authority of India
@AAL_Official
- ✕** The Fertilisers and Chemicals Travancore Limited (FACT)-owned barge Pearl of Periyar is transporting liquefied ammonia gas (LAG) from @cochin_port to Ambalamugal via the Champakkara Canal on National Waterway-3 in Kerala.

IWAI
@IWAI_ShipMin

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	April 2	April 16	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,70,000	1,72,000	1.16
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,58,000	1,57,000	-0.64
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,70,000	1,71,000	0.58
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,92,000	1,93,000	0.52
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,98,000	1,99,000	0.50
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,15,000	2,16,000	0.46
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,23,000	2,20,000	-1.36
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,64,000	1,63,000	-0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,40,000	1,39,000	-0.72
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,69,000	1,70,000	0.59
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,00,000	1,99,000	-0.50
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,00,000	1,99,000	-0.50
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,12,000	2,10,000	-0.95
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,11,000	2,12,000	0.47
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,39,000	1,40,000	0.71
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,81,000	2,80,000	-0.36
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,81,000	2,82,000	0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,63,000	1,62,000	-0.62
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,51,000	1,52,000	0.66
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,46,000	1,45,000	-0.69
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	96,000	98,000	2.04
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,58,000	1,60,000	1.25
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,51,000	1,52,000	0.66
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,12,000	1,10,000	-1.82
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	62,000	62,000	0.00
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	82,000	80,000	-2.50
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	61,000	62,000	1.61

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

SAFETY ON THE SEAS

Ship owners navigate Hormuz crisis

ALL HANDS ON DECK. How shipping firms and welfare groups are ensuring the wellbeing and safe return of seafarers

Aneesh Phadnis

For over 40 days, staff handling the helpline at the UK-headquartered International Seafarers’ Welfare and Assistance Network (ISWAN) have been fielding anxious calls from marine crew members stranded in the Persian Gulf. A third of these calls pertained to difficulties faced by seafarers in returning home while others were about employee rights.

“We have also handled cases where seafarers are experiencing stress or are hesitant to enter war-zone areas,” says Chirag Bahri, ISWAN’s international operations manager.

As the ongoing Iran-US-Israel conflagration has left the Strait of Hormuz, a vital trade lane, blockaded for more than a month, the maritime world is grappling with the human cost. Since February 28, when the war broke out, more than 20 merchant vessels have been attacked, leading to loss of lives and damage to maritime assets. More than 800 vessels, carrying 20,000-plus seafarers, are stuck in the region till date.

Welfare groups like ISWAN and shipping companies are helping the stranded seafarers navigate the choppy waters to the extent possible. While ISWAN is sensitising the crew on rationing food and essentials, the shipping firms have activated their contingency plans.

“Our vessels are operating under enhanced safety and security procedures, consistent with company protocol and current industry guidance. We have also enhanced connectivity on board to support crew in staying connected with their families, and our crew welfare teams remain available to both seafarers and their loved ones during this period,” says global ship management company Synergy Marine Group.

Mitsui OSK Lines says it has established a 24/7 support system, and remains in constant contact with its stranded vessels and crew to ensure their wellbeing.

Hapag Lloyd, which has six container vessels stuck in the Persian Gulf, has established a crisis taskforce to coordinate with its seafarers as well as customers. Asked about onboard protocols in a war zone, Hapag Lloyd responded that the



HOMECOMING. The captain and crew of LPG carrier Nanda Devi, the second Indian vessel to cross the Strait of Hormuz in March

situation calls for heightened caution and close coordination between ship and shore. “Communication with crews is absolutely key in this context. Crews are being closely informed about how the company assesses the situation and how decisions are made. Many decisions currently have to be taken day by day, depending on how the situation develops. From an operational point of view, life on board is being managed as steadily and reliably as possible,” says a spokesperson of the German container line.

BONUSES FOR SEAFARERS

On March 5, the Persian Gulf, Gulf of Oman and Strait of Hormuz were designated as a Warlike Operations Area (WOA) by the International Bargaining Forum (IBF). Set up in 2003 by the International Maritime Employers’ Council (representing 330 shipping companies) and the International Transport Workers’ Federation, the IBF negotiates global employment standards for seafarers. Ship owners from Japan, Korea and Taiwan, too, are part of the forum.

Maritime workers operating in WOA

are entitled to salary bonuses, apart from other benefits, including the right to refuse to sail into the area, paid repatriation and severance compensation for the unserved portion of the contract.

REPATRIATION CHALLENGES

However, in reality, the repatriation of seafarers from the Persian Gulf has faced hurdles with the temporary suspension of flights and the harbour boat services needed to transport crew from anchorage to shore. Those stranded at Iranian ports are particularly impacted. Forward Seamen’s Union of India (FSUI) has called for their urgent evacuation. According to the union, there are Indian seafarers stranded on 40 vessels in Iranian ports.

“We have already lost three Indian lives, with one more missing. Our foremost concern is the safe evacuation of seafarers before hostilities resume, which may occur without warning,” FSUI General Secretary Manoj Yadav said in a letter to the International Maritime Organisation on April 14.

As of April 18, the Directorate General of Shipping has facilitated the safe repat-

riation of over 2,487 Indian seafarers from the Gulf region. The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways said it has put in place measures to safeguard Indian vessels and seafarers operating in the region. A 24/7 control room has been set up for emergency response.

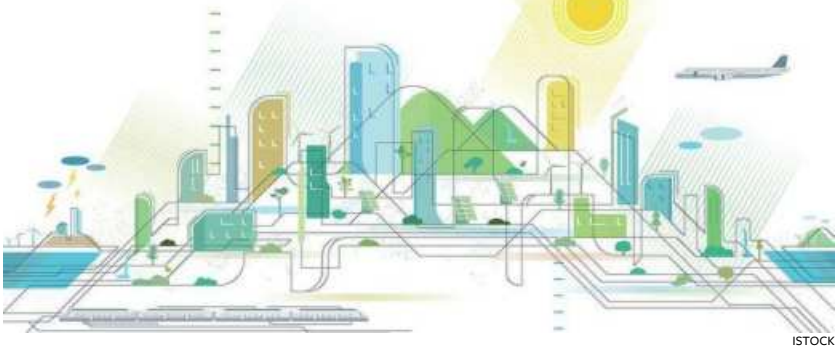
“All IMEC (International Maritime Employers’ Council) members are obliged to grant enhanced compensation/protection,” its CEO Francesco Gargiulo says. He estimates that around 500 vessels operating in the Persian Gulf area are covered by IBF agreements, but an exact figure is not available as it has not been disclosed by member companies.

“We have a number of members that have manning offices in India and utilise a huge number of Indian seafarers. These seafarers will benefit from the March 5 designation and of subsequent improvements to that,” Gargiulo added.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

URBAN EXPANSION

Critical role of logistics in the rise of TN’s ‘global city’



ROHAN GIGI GEORGE

Logistics extends beyond warehouses and freight movement to include labour mobility, supply-chain clustering and transit systems needed to connect production hubs, services, ports and airports.

In the case of Chennai, the local economy appears split along geographical divisions: The western region hosts manufacturing and logistics clusters such as Sriperumbudur and Oragadam, the central city is congested, and the south accommodates IT parks, offices and residential growth. This fragmentation results in long, cross-city commutes and inefficient freight flows. It shows that new urban nodes succeed not through master-plan ambition but by capturing and amplifying existing flows of goods, capital and talent.

As Tamil Nadu proposes its ambitious Global City project near Maduranthakam, this principle becomes particularly relevant. While large, integrated urban developments promise new economic districts, their long-term viability depends on a coherent logistics strategy. Ring roads, metro railway corridors, freight corridors and industrial logistics routes can link the planned global city to ports, clusters and talent hubs. Ongoing infrastructure projects, including metro railway expansions, the outer and peripheral ring roads, industrial corridors and the proposed Parandur international airport are gradually coalescing into a more integrated regional network.

India is witnessing a new wave of urban expansions led by State governments. Large greenfield cities are being mooted not merely as residential extensions, but also specialised economic ecosystems designed to attract global investment, in-

novation and talent. Policymakers are experimenting with new models of economic urbanism — from KWIN City near Bengaluru to Bharat Future City near Hyderabad. Avoiding the satellite-city trap — ambitious new towns often become dormitory suburbs dependent on parent cities for jobs — calls for the convergence of three forces: Strong industry clusters, enabling policies and seamless connectivity.

Gurugram, in Haryana, exemplifies this flow of enterprise, talent and capital that chose to locate there. Chennai already has several advantages, including a diverse manufacturing base spanning automobiles, electronics and heavy engineering, deep port infrastructure and a steady pipeline of engineering talent. The challenge is to integrate a new urban node into these networks. Without robust economic anchors, even well-designed districts risk remaining residential enclaves rather than growth engines.

Ultimately, Global City’s success will be determined by not just master plans or land scale, but also the convergence of jobs, investment and infrastructure. Anchored in Tamil Nadu’s industrial strengths, integrated with regional logistics, and guided by policy clarity and strategic incentives, it could transform the southern corridor into a sustainable, innovation-driven hub.

Planned developments succeed when they respond to underlying economic forces. Goods, capital and people must have reasons to move there, and the logistics networks that connect industries, workers and markets ultimately determine whether those flows materialise. When they do, cities grow organically; when they don’t, even the most ambitious master plans remain lifeless.

For Tamil Nadu’s proposed Global City, the ultimate test will be whether it can translate this alignment into a self-sustaining economic ecosystem and a genuine engine of regional growth.

The writer is a Chennai-based real estate executive

INDO-BANGLA TRADE

Export lull: Truckers’ loss mounts

Mithun Dasgupta

India’s shipments to Bangladesh through Petrapole, the largest land port in South Asia, have not revived even after the new government led by Tarique Rahman has taken charge in Dhaka. This has left the trucking industry in deep worry amid huge losses.

After a mass uprising in July 2024 toppled the Sheikh Hasina government, the number of trucks entering Bangladesh each day through the Petrapole-Benapole border has almost halved.

Rahman was sworn in as the new Prime Minister in February, after his Bangladesh National Party’s landslide win in the country’s first election held after the student-led uprising caused Hasina’s Awami League government to be ousted.

WARY EXPORTERS

During July 2024, 500-550 trucks were entering Bangladesh each day at Petrapole, a vital gateway for trade and commerce between India and Bangladesh. This number fell to 275-300 at the end of 2024.

“The number of trucks that entered Bangladesh on April 16 stood at 295, while it was 282 on April 15. So we are not seeing any improvement in shipments, which had fallen sharply around one-and-a-half years ago,” says Karthik Chakraborty, Secretary, Petrapole Clearing Agents’ Staff Welfare Association.

“Mostly due to the prevailing difficult financial conditions in Bangladesh, Indian exporters are not getting large consignments. This is why trade continues to take a hit, despite a new government taking charge

in the neighbouring country,” he adds.

Through this land port, about 80 km from Kolkata, in the North 24 Parganas district, Bangladesh imports raw cotton, iron, plastics, chemicals, onion and perishable commodities, among others, while India imports leather items, shoes, cotton rack, jute goods and fish.

As much as 30 per cent of India’s trucking industry is dependent on trade with Bangladesh. With export shipments to the neighbouring country remaining low, the trucking industry is facing staggering losses.

“Bangladesh’s economy remains under strain. This is why Indian exporters are wary of likely payment delays or defaults. Shipments through Petrapole remain low. It is badly affecting our business,” says Sajal Ghosh, Secretary, Federation of West Bengal Truck Operators’ Association.

HIKE IN PARKING FEE

Chakraborty of the Petrapole Clearing Agents’ Staff Welfare Association expresses concern over the “forceful implementation” of the newly introduced Land Port Management System (LPMS) by the Land Ports Authority of India (LPAI), alongside the “excessive” parking charges at ICP Petrapole.

“After the implementation of the Suvidha Vehicle System, exporters are already paying substantial fees for booking parking slots on the LPAI premises, along with a permitted 48-hour window for cargo movement. However, even when exporters have completed all documentation and formalities on time, delays occur due to factors beyond their control. Despite this, exporters are being compelled to pay additional parking charges beyond 48 hours. This is completely unjustified,” Chakraborty says.



EXIM ON WHEELS. The Petrapole land port, 80 km from Kolkata, is a vital gateway for trade and commerce between India and Bangladesh DEBASISH BHADURI

MY FIVE.

PRIYA KASHYAP
Chief Operating Officer and
Chief of Staff, Hero FinCorp



Meditation, play and staying curious

- 1 Power:** A powerful mind makes a powerful body. It could be strength training or *surya namaskars* — it gives my days pace, energy and resilience.
- 2 Peace:** Brilliant things happen in calm minds. The benefits of meditation cannot be fully explained. They can only be experienced. My day begins at 5.30 am with a quiet hour of meditation. Over six years, my practice has become stronger, more profound and given me clarity, peace and happiness. Quoting Rumi: “When you do things from your soul, you feel a river of joy within you.” It is in that quiet hour that you find your calling.
- 3 Play:** My best days are when I play with the kids. And playing is serious (you must win!). Whether it's football, pickleball or board games — it keeps the child in me alive. It's how I combine fitness with joy.
- 4 Purpose:** Being passionate about achieving your goal, ambitious, living at the edge of your comfort zone, learning every day — because bubbles of desire make flat water sparkle! Having a clear purpose keeps me grounded and driven.
- 5 Stay curious:** 50 minutes every day are dedicated to reading — an industry report, case study or a book — dedicated to learning. It is a way of thinking, not a list of things to do. Staying curious about evolving trends.

CAPSULE.

Countries take more ownership of immunisation

Lower-income countries have collectively contributed over \$300 million towards Gavi-supported immunisation programmes for



2025, setting a new record for annual country investment in vaccines, according to Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance.

This achievement reflects the accelerated

pace at which countries are assuming greater ownership of immunisation financing, prioritising sustainable transitions to self-sufficiency, it added. At the core of Gavi's partnership with countries is a co-financing approach that strengthens national ownership by increasing government investment in vaccines over time. Over the last five years, lower-income countries together contributed \$ 1.1 billion towards the cost of vaccines — equalling the total mobilised over the previous 13 years.

“In an increasingly constrained global financing environment, countries are stepping forward to play a lead role in securing the future of immunisation,” said Dr Sania Nishtar, CEO of Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance. “Record co-financing at this scale demonstrates that the shift toward country-led, sustainable immunisation systems is gaining momentum and that we are entering a new era when it comes to protecting children against preventable diseases.”

Of the 16 Gavi-supported countries affected by fragility and conflict, only six required co-financing waivers in 2025, underscoring the resilience of government commitment even in the most difficult contexts.

COMING UP.

New arsenal against malaria

For the first time, ending malaria in our lifetime is a real possibility. New vaccines and pioneering technologies, including genetic modification of mosquitos and long-acting injectables, are in development. On World Malaria Day (April 25), the World Health Organization joins its partners to launch the campaign ‘Driven to end malaria: Now we can. Now we must’.

● GENERIC DRIVE

Inside story of the GLP-1 rush

WORRYING GAIN. Demand for weight-loss drugs is being shaped outside controlled medical settings

J Mangaiyarkarasi

In closed social media groups and other online forums, users of weight-loss drugs compare dosages, swap sourcing tips and discuss methods of storing low-cost vials.

Offline, they walk into clinics, asking for the drug by name — “I want GLP-1.” Or “Which is better... Ozempic or Mounjaro?”

Earlier, most people had “injection-phobia and preferred oral medications,” says senior endocrinologist Dr V Kumaravel. Today, they ask outright for a range of injectable weight-loss drugs by name, says the Madurai-based doctor, who is a member of the Endocrine Society of Tamil Nadu.

This despite the Union Health Ministry and doctors cautioning that while GLP-1 (glucagon-like peptide-1), including semaglutide or tirzepatide, is a breakthrough drug, it has side-effects and cannot be used indiscriminately. (Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Danish company Novo Nordisk's obesity drug Wegovy and diabetes drug Ozempic; and tirzepatide is sold by American company Eli Lilly as obesity drug Mounjaro.)

Generic versions of semaglutide have exploded since late March, after its patent expired, with local drugmakers launching versions that are 50-80 per cent cheaper. Over 25 generic brands are available in vials, reusable pens and as oral tablets, plunging the monthly cost from ₹10,000–₹17,000 to ₹1,290 (Natco Pharma's product).

Lilly's tirzepatide is still under patent and costs ₹15,000–₹20,000, but continues to top this category.

The worrying side of the GLP-1-fuelled weight-loss story is that demand for the drugs is being shaped outside medical settings, doctors warn.

“Most people come after seeing Instagram or hearing from someone who has taken it,” Dr Kumaravel says. “We evaluate



● INJECTING HOPE

- GLP-1 drugs treat obesity and type 2 diabetes. They mimic a naturally occurring hormone that regulates blood sugar and appetite. They increase insulin secretion, reduce glucagon release, slow gastric emptying and promote satiety, helping patients eat less
- Market size is pegged at ₹5,000 crore
- GLP-1 drugs available in India: Semaglutide injection, semaglutide tablets, liraglutide, tirzepatide, dulaglutide, exenatide, and exenatide extended release

whether it is suitable (for them),” he says, adding that only a small fraction of them eventually receive the prescription.

The clamour for GLP-1 drugs is amplified by gyms, “wellness clinics”, and online and offline peer recommendations, another physician in a tier-2 city says.

Social media and online discussion platforms are inundated with “user experiences” — sharing of “before” and “after” photos as evidence of weight loss from shots taken at home, recording of daily “progress”, and scouting for “prescribers” or attempting to bypass prescriptions altogether.

BATTLE AGAINST OBESITY

Before GLP-1 drugs, there were limited medical options for obesity. Doctors advised diet and exercise, but patients did not find them effective, says Dr Kumaravel. “In that gap, many unregulated remedies came up, none of them evidence-based. When GLP drugs came in, they entered with strong efficacy,” he explains.

A Mumbai-based GLP-1 user (who declined to be named) says:

“I got tired of working hard and still not losing weight... Then I found out how much GLP-1s helped people, especially with PCOS (polycystic ovarian syndrome). There are a lot of side effects, so I was hesitant. But I've been living with a different set of side effects anyway. So I decided to pick my struggle.”

The known side-effects include nausea, vomiting, bloating, diarrhoea, constipation, tachycardia and dizziness.

Global health authorities caution against other possible serious side-effects like vision loss, kidney failure and thyroid cancer.

“One of the earlier reported side effects of semaglutide was sudden blindness... known as non-arteritic anterior ischemic optic neuropathy. With mass usage, people have forgotten about this,” Dr Kumaravel says.

Meanwhile, several users who did reach their target weight have reported renewed cravings and weight gain once the drug is discontinued.

Jitendra Chouksey, Founder-CEO of health platform FITTR, points out that GLP-1s were

never meant to replace a healthy lifestyle.

“If these drugs were truly helping, wouldn't we have seen a reduction in obesity prevalence globally?” he asks. “Instead, what we are seeing is a short-term impact with low long-term adherence... and rising obesity prevalence worldwide without a pause.”

He also cautions on heart-related impacts after discontinuation. “A recent study showed that degradation of cardiac health is much faster — up to 22 per cent in 18 months — once the drug use is stopped,” he says, adding that the absence of sustained benefits raises questions about long-term dependence on the drug.

He warns that access to the drug has already expanded beyond tightly controlled medical settings.

Echoing this, Dr Kumaravel says, “It [the decision] has moved from a doctor's clinic to a consumer market.” And while “the government can control the doctor market... controlling consumers or mob behaviour is much harder,” he rues.

● FROM THE REGULATOR

‘Reveal unfavourable clinical trial results too’

The United States Food and Drug Administration has reminded more than 2,200 medical product companies and researchers of the requirement to submit certain clinical trial results to ClinicalTrials.gov.

Companies and researchers often fail to disclose negative results, resulting in significant gaps in the public record and a publication bias that obscures the true landscape of drug development outcomes — over-representing successes and under-representing failures. This gap can also create a distorted perception of the safety and efficacy of medical products.

According to an internal analysis, 29.6 per cent of studies that are highly likely to fall under mandatory reporting requirements have no results information submitted to ClinicalTrials.gov. Studies subject to the mandatory reporting requirements include interventional studies with a US nexus and an FDA-regulated product, which are past the reporting deadline; it excludes Phase 1 and device feasibility studies.

“Far too often, companies are suppressing unfavourable clinical trial results and keeping them secret from patients and the scientific community. Those sponsoring clinical trials have an ethical obligation to make results public regardless of the data's influence on the company's share price,” said FDA Commissioner Marty Makary.

“Too many clinical trial sponsors and researchers are failing to report their results, leaving important information unavailable to clinicians and other researchers. If you are a doctor deciding whether or not to prescribe a medication to a patient, you deserve to have the best data about clinical studies on that medication.”

Certain clinical trial sponsors and researchers are required to submit clinical trial results to ClinicalTrials.gov one year after trial completion. On March 30, the agency sent messages to more than 2,200 companies and researchers (associated with more than 3,000 registered clinical trials, including some that were publicly funded) that did not appear to have submitted required results to ClinicalTrials.gov or may have not completed the National Library of Medicine's quality control review process. The messages seek voluntary compliance with requirements.

Source: USFDA



LENS ON HEALTH



LEAVING NONE BEHIND. Healthcare workers search for people who have not been vaccinated against measles, as part of a vaccination campaign, in the Emmanuel neighbourhood of Mejicanos, El Salvador REUTERS

Stalling the silent spread of tuberculosis cases

BY INVITATION

MADHAV JOSHI



TIMELY DIAGNOSIS. Portable, handheld X-ray devices enable on-the-spot TB screening even in remote settings SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

India's tuberculosis (TB) response has undergone a quiet but significant shift. In 2025, over 26 lakh TB patients were notified — the highest ever. This is not a setback — it reflects progress. Finding more cases is exactly what success looks like in the early stages of elimination. It means fewer infections going undetected or spreading silently.

This shift is already translating into impact. India is reducing TB incidence at nearly twice the global average — progress that only becomes possible when patients are diagnosed early and treated fully.

Historically, diagnosis has been the weakest link. Even today, globally over 3 million TB patients go undiagnosed, allowing the disease to spread silently. India's response is changing that narrative. The fundamental shift is that instead of waiting for patients to seek care, reaching it actively to those who need it.

Today, diagnosis is being brought closer to communities. Portable, handheld X-ray devices, supported by artificial intelligence, enable on-the-spot screening even in remote settings. Molecular diagnostic tests at the district level can now detect TB and drug resistance within two hours, significantly reducing delays and loss of follow-ups.

Crucially, emerging evidence has reshaped our understanding of TB. A substantial section of patients may have no symptoms — cough or fever — yet continue to transmit the disease. India's largescale community screening efforts are beginning to address this lacuna. Under the TB Mukh Bharat Abhiyan initiative, a significant share of detected patients was found to have no symptoms, underscoring the importance of proactive screening.

INNOVATION PIPELINE

The future of TB testing is filled with remarkable patient-centric tools, promising affordability, decentralisation and, eventually, even self-admin-

Medical supply chain leaks: Where does the buck stop?

An expose on sale of sub-par cancer drugs raises questions on end-to-end visibility in supply of critical medicines

PT Jyothi Datta

For those dealing with cancer, the pain and trauma of the illness and treatment, including the steep costs, are all too familiar.

Add to this the possibility that the cancer medicine being administered is an ineffective substance peddled in the original packaging.

This was alleged by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (along with 47 media partners), putting the spotlight on Merck's cancer drug Keytruda. The investigative report involving this drug in India further raises questions on supply chain sanctity, safe disposal of medical waste (vials) and accountability.

Questions remain on who has end-to-end visibility on the supply chain of critical medicines and who will be held re-



sponsible when that chain is diverted or manipulated?

There has to be a standard operating procedure (SOP) for the movement of drugs (vials, in this case) from the manufacturers to the distributors, pharmacies, hospitals, doctors, patients and waste management agencies, says R Uday Bhaskar, Honorary Director General, All India Drugs Control Officers' Confederation. There should

be criminal action against those found guilty of diversion and repackaging, among other malpractices, he said.

Cancer patients are often directed by people in the healthcare ecosystem to collect their expensive medicines from the chemist at the hospital or recommended distributors — to secure some reprieve on the cost, say multiple healthcare voices.

Faced with mounting bills, the patients do as told. And since the drug is packed and sealed, they have no reason to suspect something may be amiss, they add.

Cancer medicines are expensive, and leaks in the supply chain bring in “rogue” elements that look to exploit desperate patients and their families, observes KM Gopakumar, Co-convenor, Working Group

on Access to Medicines and Treatment. The price of a 4 ml vial is about ₹1.8 lakh, according to industry data.

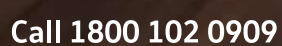
Companies are required to have a track-and-trace system for medicines, says an industry insider. So a stock check on vials supplied and the number used and disposed of should show up discrepancies in the supply chain, he adds.

MSD's pembrolizumab (brand name Keytruda) is approved in India for over 14 indications, across eight different types of tumours. It works with the body's immune system to help detect and fight cancer cells and is different from chemotherapy or radiation therapy, according to company data. The company also runs a patient assistance programme for this drug.

An email query was sent by *businessline* to MSD (Merck & Co Inc) on the alleged misuse of Keytruda vials in India. A response is awaited.



Price starting at ₹10.99 Lakh*



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